BAL GOKUL OF PRINCE WILLIAM COUNTY · 2026–27 · GRADES 9–12

PASSPORT
TIRTHA
2026–27

Sacred Geography

Hindu Temples and Pilgrimage Places

Presentation slides for all 25 classes · each class runs 30 minutes: Wonder, Learn, Map, Explore, Quiz, Reflect

Class 1

What Makes a Place Sacred?

PASSPORT
TIRTHA
2026–27

Sunday, October 4, 2026 · Unit 1: Foundations: Sacred Place, Temple and Pilgrimage

3 min Wonder | **7** min Learn | **3** min Map | **9** min Explore | **5** min Quiz | **3** min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

Why do some places become sacred while others do not, and who decides?

Think of a place sacred to any community. Is its sacredness in the land itself, in the stories told about it, or in the people who keep returning?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

What Makes a Place Sacred?

Tirtha: the crossing

The Sanskrit tirtha first meant a ford, a shallow place to cross a river. Texts such as the Mahabharata describe pilgrimage to tirthas, and the word became a metaphor for crossing from ordinary life toward the divine.

A sacred geography

Hindu traditions map meaning onto the land: rivers honored as goddesses (Ganga, Yamuna), mountains as divine abodes (Kailash), cities as sacred centers (Kashi). Scholar Diana Eck explores this idea in India: A Sacred Geography (2012).

Three lenses

Scholars often study sacred places through narrative (stories that mark the site), practice (bathing, darshan, circling the site) and community (priests, pilgrims and families who sustain it).

Insider and outsider

Religious studies separates describing what devotees hold (the emic view) from analyzing it from outside (the etic view). Writing “many Hindus believe” keeps claims accurate and respectful.

LEARN

Key terms

tirtha	TEER-tha	ford; a sacred crossing place
kshetra	KSHAY-tra	a sacred field or region
emic / etic	EE-mik / ET-ik	insider description / outsider analysis

MAP

Where in the world?



1 **Varanasi (Kashi)** Uttar Pradesh

Ancient city on the Ganga with stone ghats and the Kashi Vishwanath temple of Shiva.

2 **Haridwar** Uttarakhand

Where the Ganga leaves the mountains for the plains. Evening aarti at Har ki Pauri ghat.

3 **Gangotri** Uttarakhand

Temple of Goddess Ganga, near the glacier where the river begins.

4 **Mount Kailash** Tibet (China)

Mountain linked with Shiva. Pilgrims walk around it (about 52 km) instead of climbing it.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

What Makes a Place Sacred?

WHOLE CLASS

Place Varanasi, Haridwar, Gangotri and Mount Kailash on the map. Note how all four connect to the Ganga or the Himalayas.

YOUR TASK

In small groups, take one site. Explain its sacredness through all three lenses: narrative, practice and community. Give a 60-second case to the class.

DISCUSS

Can a place lose its sacredness? Consider pollution of the Ganga, mass tourism or rapid urban growth.

ACTIVITY

Narrative, practice or community?

Place each card in a group.

- Kailash described as Shiva’s abode
- Story of the Ganga descending from heaven
- Ritual bath at Har ki Pauri, Haridwar
- King Bhagiratha’s penance brings the river to earth
- Evening Ganga aarti
- Walking the circuit around Kailash
- Boatmen families serving pilgrims for generations
- Haridwar priests keeping family genealogy registers

NARRATIVE	PRACTICE	COMMUNITY

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Narrative, practice or community?

NARRATIVE

- Story of the Ganga descending from heaven
- Kailash described as Shiva’s abode
- King Bhagiratha’s penance brings the river to earth

PRACTICE

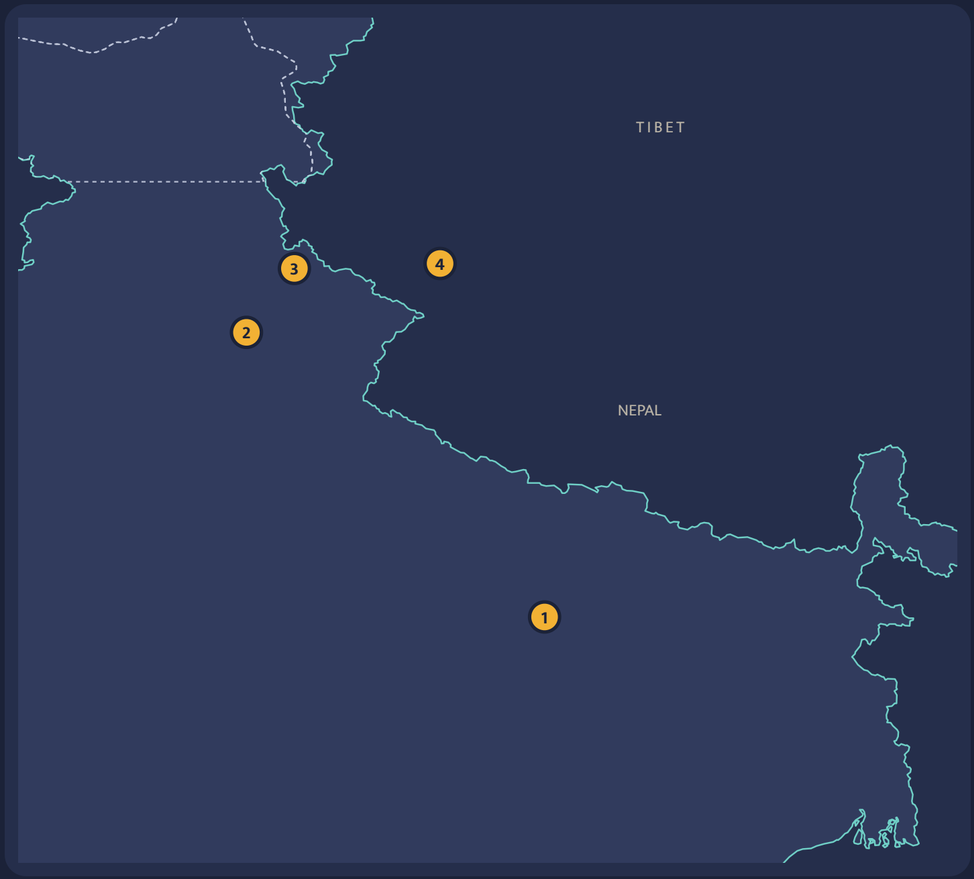
- Ritual bath at Har ki Pauri, Haridwar
- Walking the circuit around Kailash
- Evening Ganga aarti

COMMUNITY

- Haridwar priests keeping family genealogy registers
- Boatmen families serving pilgrims for generations

ACTIVITY

Find it on the map



Which number is each site?

Mount Kailash → ___

Varanasi (Kashi) → __

Haridwar → ___

Gangotri → __

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Find it on the map

1 Varanasi (Kashi)

2 Haridwar

3 Gangotri

4 Mount Kailash

QUIZ · QUESTION 1 OF 5

What did the word tirtha originally mean?

- **A** A temple tower
- **B** A royal decree
- **C** A festival season
- **D** A ford or river crossing

Which statement is emic (an insider description)?

A “For devotees, bathing at the Sangam washes away sins.”

B “Pilgrimage boosts the regional economy.”

C “The Ganga basin supports 400 million people.”

D “Pilgrim numbers rise in winter.”

At Haridwar, many priestly families are known for keeping…

- **A** Genealogy registers of pilgrim families
- **B** Weather logs
- **C** Temple blueprints
- **D** Tax records

Mount Kailash is sacred to which traditions?

A Only Hindu

B None; it is a climbing peak

C Hindu, Buddhist, Jain and Bon

D Only Buddhist

Which phrasing best fits academic writing?

A “Many Hindus regard the Ganga as a goddess.”

B “Hindus worship rivers.”

C “The Ganga is a goddess.”

D “Everyone in India bathes in the Ganga.”

QUIZ

Answers

1 **D. A ford or river crossing**

The meaning grew from a physical crossing to a spiritual one.

2 **A. “For devotees, bathing at the Sangam washes away sins.”**

Emic statements report meaning from inside the tradition.

3 **A. Genealogy registers of pilgrim families**

Families can trace ancestors’ visits across generations.

4 **C. Hindu, Buddhist, Jain and Bon**

Shared sacred landscapes are a theme of this course.

5 **A. “Many Hindus regard the Ganga as a goddess.”**

It is accurate, specific and avoids generalizing.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Write a thesis sentence: “A place becomes sacred when…” Support it with evidence from one of today’s sites.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today’s place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, OCTOBER 11, 2026

Class 2: Inside a Hindu Temple

Class 2

Inside a Hindu Temple

Sunday, October 11, 2026 · Unit 1: Foundations: Sacred Place, Temple and Pilgrimage

PASSPORT DARSHAN 2026-27

3 min Wonder | 10 min Learn | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

How does a building tell you how to move, where to look and how to feel?

Compare a temple, a cathedral, a stadium and a shopping mall.

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Inside a Hindu Temple

A path toward the center

Many temples lead visitors from a gateway through halls of increasing sanctity to the garbhagriha (“womb chamber”), a small, dim inner shrine. Movement through space mirrors an inward journey.

Tower and shrine

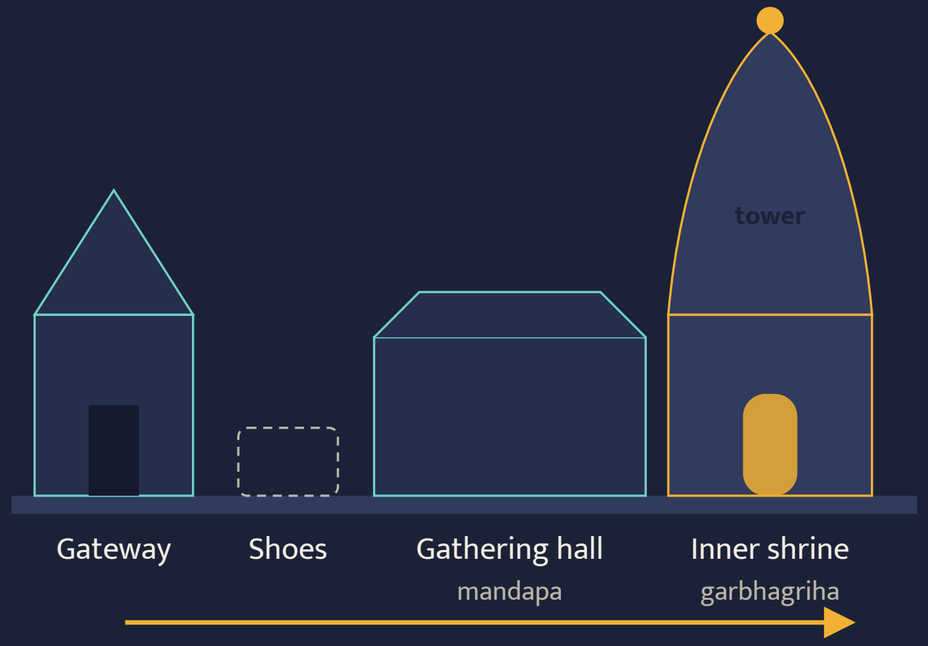
The tower above the shrine (shikhara in the north, vimana in the south) marks the sacred center from far away. Texts on architecture, the Vastu and Shilpa Shastras, set out proportions and plans.

Darshan

Darshan means seeing and being seen by the deity. Scholars such as Diana Eck describe it as a two-way exchange of sight, which is why the murti’s eyes matter so much.

Puja and prasad

Puja offers light, flowers, food and water. Food offered and returned is prasad. Many temples also circle the shrine clockwise (pradakshina).



LEARN

Key terms

garbhagriha	GAR-bha-gri-ha	inner shrine room
pradakshina	pra-DUK-shi-na	clockwise circling
Vastu Shastra	VAAS-too SHAAS-tra	texts on sacred design
murti	MOOR-ti	sacred image

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Inside a Hindu Temple

WHOLE CLASS

Use the temple diagram to trace a visitor’s path from gateway to shrine.

YOUR TASK

Compare two floor plans (a North Indian and a South Indian temple). Write three observations about how space, light and movement shape a visit.

DISCUSS

Diaspora temples in the US often combine many deities, classrooms and kitchens under one roof. What changes when a temple is built far from its home region?

ACTIVITY

Match the terms

Match each item on the left with one on the right.

1 prasad	A seeing and being seen by the deity
2 pradakshina	B sacred image of a deity
3 mandapa	C inner shrine room
4 garbhagriha	D pillared hall for gathering
5 puja	E worship with offerings
6 murti	F food offered and returned as blessing
7 darshan	G clockwise circling of the shrine

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Match the terms

1 → F prasad — food offered and returned as blessing

2 → G pradakshina — clockwise circling of the shrine

3 → D mandapa — pillared hall for gathering

4 → C garbhagriha — inner shrine room

5 → E puja — worship with offerings

6 → B murti — sacred image of a deity

7 → A darshan — seeing and being seen by the deity

ACTIVITY

Order the spaces, outer to inner

Put these in the correct order.

A Gateway

B Mandapa (hall)

C Antarala (vestibule)

D Outer courtyard

E Garbhagriha (inner shrine)

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Order the spaces, outer to inner

1. Gateway
2. Outer courtyard
3. Mandapa (hall)
4. Antarala (vestibule)
5. Garbhagriha (inner shrine)

Why is the garbhagriha usually small and dim?

A. It concentrates attention on the murti, the sacred center

B. To store temple records

C. Because lamps were banned

D. To save building costs

Darshan is best described as…

- **A** A silent prayer
- **B** A dance form
- **C** A temple tax
- **D** A two-way exchange of sight between devotee and deity

Which texts give rules for temple proportions and plans?

A Arthashastra

B Panchatantra

C Ramayana

D Vastu and Shilpa Shastras

QUIZ · QUESTION 4 OF 4

Pradakshina is performed...

A Counter-clockwise

B Only by priests

C Only at night

D Clockwise, keeping the shrine on the right

QUIZ

Answers

1. **A. It concentrates attention on the murti, the sacred center**

   Space and light focus the visit inward.

2. **D. A two-way exchange of sight between devotee and deity**

   This is why the murti's eyes are so significant.

3. **D. Vastu and Shilpa Shastras**

   They are treatises on architecture and image-making.

4. **D. Clockwise, keeping the shrine on the right**

   Many temples have a circumambulation path.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Describe how one feature of temple design (path, light, tower or hall) shapes a visitor's experience. Use one specific term from today.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, OCTOBER 18, 2026

Class 3: Architecture Across Regions

Class 3

Architecture Across Regions

PASSPORT SHIKHARA 2026-27

Sunday, October 18, 2026 · Unit 1: Foundations: Sacred Place, Temple and Pilgrimage

3 min Wonder | 7 min Learn | 3 min Map | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

Why would two kingdoms in the same religious tradition build temples that look so different?

Consider materials, climate, rulers, guilds of artisans and competition.

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Architecture Across Regions

Nagara (north)

A curvilinear shikhara rising over the shrine, often clustered with smaller tower forms. Example: Kandariya Mahadeva at Khajuraho (c. 1030 CE).

Dravida (south)

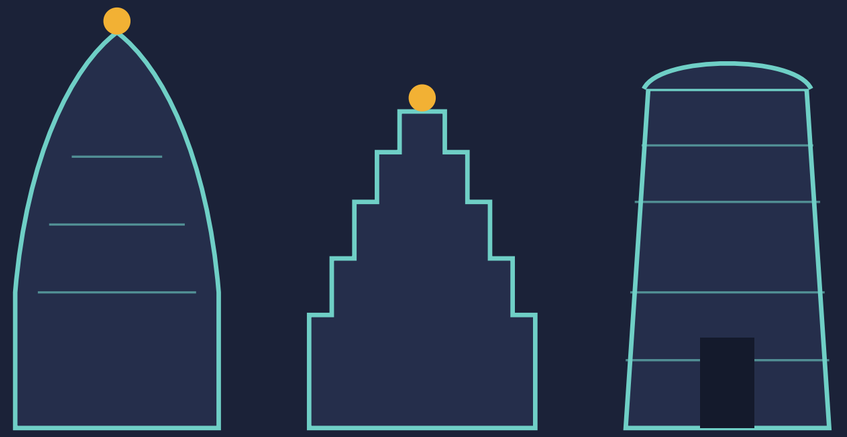
A stepped, pyramidal vimana. Brihadisvara at Thanjavur (c. 1010 CE) has a giant vimana; later southern temples shift emphasis to huge gopurams at the gates.

Vesara and Kalinga

Vesara blends northern and southern features in the Deccan. At Pattadakal (7th–8th c.) both styles stand together. Kalinga is Odisha's variant, seen at Lingaraja, Bhubaneswar.

Rock-cut

The Kailasa temple (Ellora Cave 16, 8th c.) was carved downward from a single basalt cliff. Builders could only remove stone, never add it.



Shikhara
Nagara, north

Vimana
Dravida, south

Gopuram
gateway, south

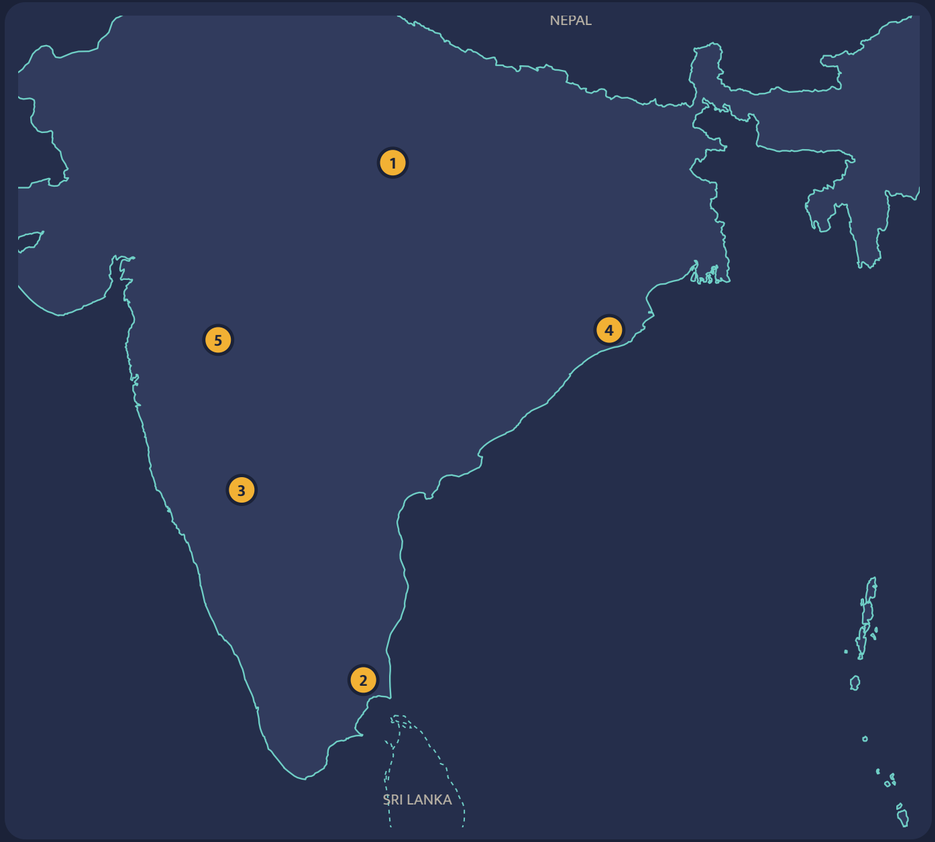
LEARN

Key terms

shikhara	SHIK-ha-ra	curved northern tower
vimana	vi-MAA-na	stepped southern tower
gopuram	GO-pu-ram	gateway tower
Vesara	VAY-sa-ra	mixed Deccan style

MAP

Where in the world?



1 **Khajuraho** Madhya Pradesh

Chandela-era temples (about 950–1050 CE) with tall, curved Nagara towers.

2 **Thanjavur** Tamil Nadu

Brihadisvara temple, completed around 1010 CE by the Chola king Rajaraja I.

3 **Pattadakal** Karnataka

Northern (Nagara) and southern (Dravida) temple styles built side by side.

4 **Bhubaneswar** Odisha

City of temples. The Lingaraja temple shows the Kalinga style.

5 **Ellora** Maharashtra

Hindu, Buddhist and Jain caves. The Kailasa temple was carved from one rock.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Architecture Across Regions

WHOLE CLASS

Sort the style clues, then compare the three tower silhouettes.

YOUR TASK

Typology is a tool, not a rule. Choose one temple and argue whether it fits neatly into one style label or blends several. Use two visual details as evidence.

DISCUSS

Why might a later southern dynasty make gateways taller than the central shrine? What does that say about public display and power?

ACTIVITY

Which style?

Place each card in a group.

- Curvilinear shikhara
- Brihadisvara, Thanjavur
- Stepped pyramidal vimana
- Kandariya Mahadeva, Khajuraho
- Lingaraja, Bhubaneswar (Kalinga variant)
- Kailasa temple, Ellora
- Shaped by removing stone only
- Monumental gateway gopurams

NAGARA	DRAVIDA	ROCK-CUT

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Which style?

NAGARA

- Curvilinear shikhara
- Kandariya Mahadeva, Khajuraho
- Lingaraja, Bhubaneswar (Kalinga variant)

DRAVIDA

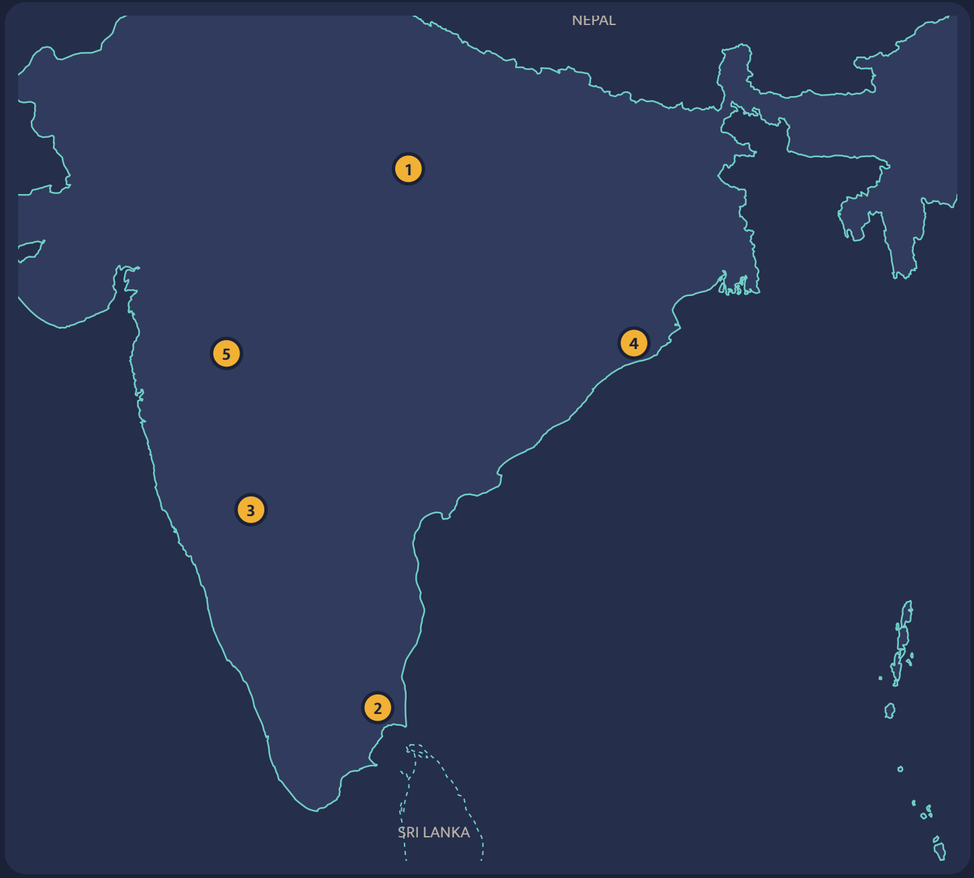
- Stepped pyramidal vimana
- Brihadisvara, Thanjavur
- Monumental gateway gopurams

ROCK-CUT

- Kailasa temple, Ellora
- Shaped by removing stone only

ACTIVITY

Find it on the map



Which number is each site?

- Khajuraho → ___
- Thanjavur → ___
- Pattadakal → __
- Ellora → ___
- Bhubaneswar → ___

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Find it on the map

1 Khajuraho

2 Thanjavur

3 Pattadakal

4 Bhubaneswar

5 Ellora

QUIZ · QUESTION 1 OF 4

Which feature defines the Nagara style?

- **A** A flat roof
- **B** A curvilinear shikhara over the shrine
- **C** Giant gateway towers
- **D** Rock-cut halls

Why is Pattadakal important to architectural history?

A It has no carvings

B Northern and southern styles stand side by side

C It is the oldest temple

D It is made of wood

What made the Kailasa temple an engineering feat?

- **A** It floats on water
- **B** It was carved downward from one cliff
- **C** It was built in a year
- **D** It was assembled from metal

What is the strongest critique of style labels?

- **A** The labels are too new
- **B** They only apply to Nepal
- **C** They are illegal
- **D** Real temples often blend features across categories

QUIZ

Answers

1. **B. A curvilinear shikhara over the shrine**

   Khajuraho is a classic example.

2. **B. Northern and southern styles stand side by side**

   It shows experimentation under the Chalukyas.

3. **B. It was carved downward from one cliff**

   Mistakes could not be undone.

4. **D. Real temples often blend features across categories**

   Typologies simplify a messy reality.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

In two sentences, explain one strength and one limitation of classifying temples by style.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, OCTOBER 25, 2026

Class 4: The Pilgrim's Journey

Class 4

The Pilgrim's Journey

Sunday, October 25, 2026 · Unit 1: Foundations: Sacred Place, Temple and Pilgrimage

PASSPORT YATRA 2026-27

3 min Wonder | 10 min Learn | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

Is a pilgrimage mainly about arriving, or about the journey itself?

Think of any long journey you've made with a purpose.

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

The Pilgrim's Journey

Yatra

A tirtha yatra is a journey to a sacred place. Motives include devotion, gratitude, a vow, prayer for family, rites for ancestors, learning and community.

Liminality

Anthropologist Victor Turner described pilgrims as entering a "liminal" in-between state, leaving ordinary roles behind and sharing a sense of equality he called communitas.

The journey matters

Walking, singing, fasting, shared meals and hardship are often seen as meaningful in themselves, not just obstacles.

Changing pilgrimage

Trains, roads, helicopters and online booking have opened sacred sites to millions, raising questions about access, cost and crowding.

LEARN

Key terms

yatra	YAA-tra	journey, pilgrimage
liminality	lim-i-NAL-i-tee	in-between state
communitas	kom-YOO-ni-tas	shared sense of equality
vrata	VRUH-ta	vow

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

The Pilgrim's Journey

WHOLE CLASS

Arrange the journey stages and discuss what changes for a pilgrim at each stage.

YOUR TASK

Plan a family pilgrimage to a site of your choice. Account for distance, cost, season, accessibility for elders and environmental impact. Present one trade-off you faced.

DISCUSS

Does a helicopter ride to a mountain shrine change the meaning of pilgrimage? Make the case for both sides.

ACTIVITY

Stages of a pilgrimage

Put these in the correct order.

- **A** Prepare (vow, packing, farewells)
- **B** Darshan and rituals
- **C** Remember and retell
- **D** Share food and prasad
- **E** Travel
- **F** Return home
- **G** Arrive

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Stages of a pilgrimage

1. Prepare (vow, packing, farewells)
2. Travel
3. Arrive
4. Darshan and rituals
5. Share food and prasad
6. Return home
7. Remember and retell

ACTIVITY

Turner's ideas or not?

Place each card in a group.

Strangers share meals on the road

Separate luxury tours from other pilgrims

VIP darshan lines for paying visitors

Social rank matters less during the journey

Pilgrims wear simple, similar clothing

FITS LIMINALITY / COMMUNITAS

DOESN'T FIT

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Turner's ideas or not?

FITS LIMINALITY / COMMUNITAS

- Pilgrims wear simple, similar clothing
- Strangers share meals on the road
- Social rank matters less during the journey

DOESN'T FIT

- VIP darshan lines for paying visitors
- Separate luxury tours from other pilgrims

Turner used “communitas” to describe…

- **A** A tax on pilgrims
- **B** A shared sense of equality among pilgrims
- **C** A sacred river
- **D** A type of temple

Which is a liminal experience?

- **A** Being between ordinary life and the destination
- **B** Sleeping at home
- **C** Shopping
- **D** Paying a bill

Which is a common motive for pilgrimage?

- **A** Earning a salary
- **B** Fulfilling a vow
- **C** Military service
- **D** Avoiding school

QUIZ · QUESTION 4 OF 4

Which development most changed access to pilgrimage sites?

A Telescopes

B Sundials

C Printing presses

D Modern transport such as railways and roads

QUIZ

Answers

1. **B. A shared sense of equality among pilgrims**

   Pilgrims step outside ordinary social roles.

2. **A. Being between ordinary life and the destination**

   Liminal means in-between.

3. **B. Fulfilling a vow**

   Vows (vratas) often motivate journeys.

4. **D. Modern transport such as railways and roads**

   Access expanded to millions.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Answer with an example: how can a journey change a person, and does ease of travel change that?

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 15, 2026

Class 5: Reading Sources and Sacred Narratives

Class 5

Reading Sources and Sacred Narratives

PASSPORT
SOURCES
2026–27

Sunday, November 15, 2026 · Unit 1: Foundations: Sacred Place, Temple and Pilgrimage

3 min Wonder | **10** min Learn | **9** min Explore | **5** min Quiz | **3** min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

Can a story be true in a different way from a history book?

What kinds of truth do communities care about?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Reading Sources and Sacred Narratives

Kinds of sources

Narratives (epics, Puranas, sthala puranas or local temple histories), objects, places, images and written records such as inscriptions, travel accounts and colonial surveys.

Source questions

Who made it? When? For whom? Why? What can it not tell us? Every source has a perspective.

Sacred narratives

Sacred stories carry meaning, values and memory for devotees. Historians treat them as evidence of belief and practice, not as proof of events.

Outside observers

Travelers such as Xuanzang (7th c.) and Al-Biruni (11th c.), and later colonial officials, wrote about Indian religion. Their accounts are valuable but shaped by their own assumptions.

LEARN

Key terms

sthala purana	STHUL-a poo-RAA-na	a temple’s local origin story
inscription	in-SKRIP-shun	text carved on stone or copper
provenance	PROV-e-nunce	where a source comes from

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Reading Sources and Sacred Narratives

WHOLE CLASS

Sort the source cards by type, then rank two of them by how useful they are for a specific question.

YOUR TASK

Question: “Why did pilgrims visit this temple in the 1100s?” Rank three sources (a sthala purana, a royal inscription, a modern travel blog) by usefulness. Justify each ranking with the source questions.

DISCUSS

Can an outsider’s account ever be more accurate than an insider’s? When might it be less accurate?

ACTIVITY

Source type

Place each card in a group.

A temple’s sthala purana

Bronze Nataraja

Copper-plate land grant

Ghats of Varanasi

Mughal-era miniature painting

19th-century photograph of a festival

Al-Biruni’s account of India

Ramayana episode

NARRATIVE	OBJECT	PLACE	IMAGE	WRITTEN RECORD

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Source type

NARRATIVE

- A temple's sthala purana
- Ramayana episode

OBJECT

- Bronze Nataraja

PLACE

- Ghats of Varanasi

IMAGE

- 19th-century photograph of a festival
- Mughal-era miniature painting

WRITTEN RECORD

- Copper-plate land grant
- Al-Biruni's account of India

A copper-plate land grant to a temple is best used to learn…

- **A** Who funded the temple and what they gave
- **B** The weather that year
- **C** Modern visitor numbers
- **D** Exact beliefs of every visitor

Historians treat sacred narratives as evidence of…

A Scientific facts

B Exact historical events

C What communities believed and valued

D Nothing useful

Why read colonial surveys critically?

- **A** Their authors' assumptions shaped what they recorded
- **B** They are always fake
- **C** They are too short
- **D** They were written in Sanskrit

What is a sthala purana?

- **A** A dance
- **B** A temple’s local origin story
- **C** A tax receipt
- **D** A map

QUIZ

Answers

1 **A. Who funded the temple and what they gave**

Grants record donors, gifts and dates.

2 **C. What communities believed and valued**

They answer questions about belief and memory.

3 **A. Their authors' assumptions shaped what they recorded**

Every source has a perspective.

4 **B. A temple's local origin story**

Many temples have one.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Choose one source type and explain one question it can answer well and one it cannot.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 22, 2026

Class 6: Varanasi and Kashi Vishwanath

Class 6

Varanasi and Kashi Vishwanath

Sunday, November 22, 2026 · Unit 2: Sacred Rivers, Cities and Northern Routes

PASSPORT
KASHI
2026–27

3 min Wonder | 7 min Learn | 3 min Map | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

How can a city be a home, a marketplace, a university town and a sacred center at once?

Who might experience Varanasi differently?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Varanasi and Kashi Vishwanath

Kashi, Banaras, Varanasi

On the Ganga's western bank in Uttar Pradesh, often described as one of the world's oldest continuously inhabited cities. Kashi means "city of light."

Ghats and the river

More than 80 ghats line the river. They host bathing, worship, laundry, wrestling, music and cremation at Manikarnika and Harishchandra ghats.

Kashi Vishwanath

A Jyotirlinga temple of Shiva. Destroyed and rebuilt several times; Queen Ahilyabai Holkar built the present temple in 1780. The Kashi Vishwanath Corridor (opened 2021) linked it to the river.

Many meanings

Many Hindus regard dying in Kashi as granting liberation (moksha). The city is also a center of Banarasi silk, Hindustani music and Banaras Hindu University.

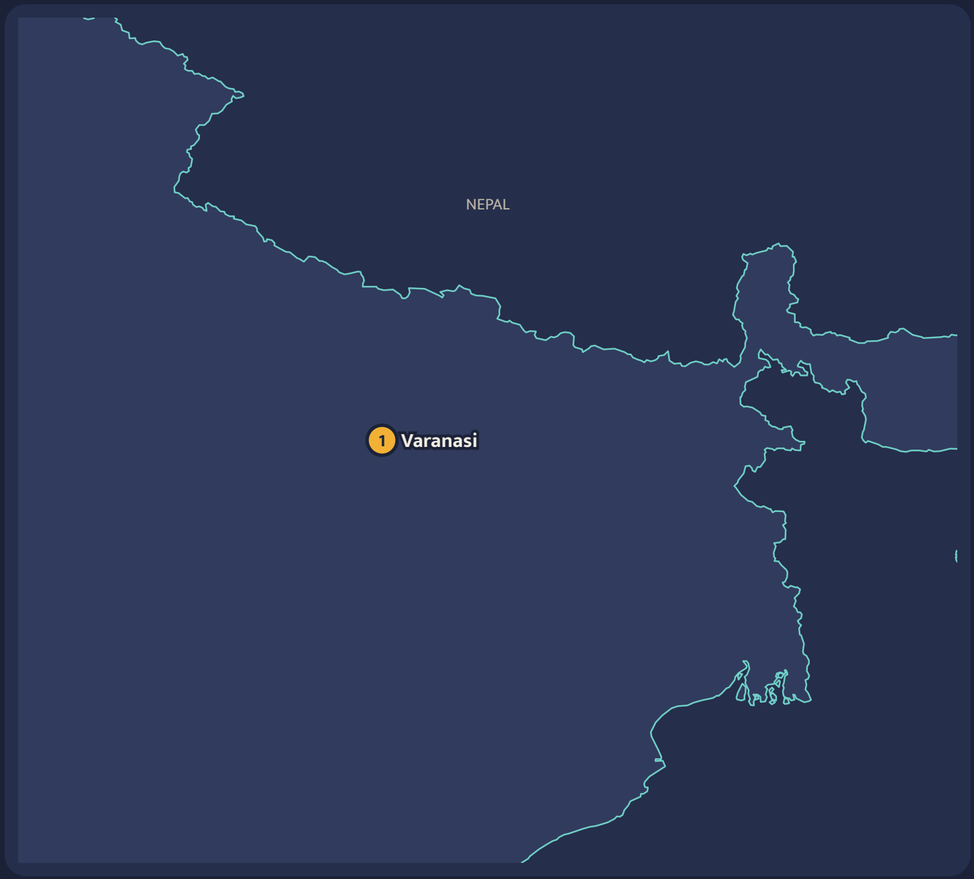
LEARN

Key terms

ghat	GAAT	steps to a river
moksha	MOKE-sha	liberation
aarti	AAR-tee	worship with lamps

MAP

Where in the world?



1 **Varanasi (Kashi)** Uttar Pradesh

Ancient city on the Ganga with stone ghats and the Kashi Vishwanath temple of Shiva.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Varanasi and Kashi Vishwanath

WHOLE CLASS

Follow a photo journey from the river to the temple lanes.

YOUR TASK

Annotate a city map showing religious, residential and commercial spaces. Then identify one place where these overlap and explain the tension or harmony.

DISCUSS

The 2021 corridor made the temple easier to reach but cleared old lanes and homes. How should cities balance access, heritage and residents' needs?

ACTIVITY

One city, many meanings

Place each card in a group.

Kashi Vishwanath

Hindustani music gharanas

Banaras Hindu University

Boatmen ferrying visitors

Cremation at Manikarnika ghat

Banarasi silk looms

Hospices for the dying

Evening Ganga aarti

WORSHIP

LEARNING & ARTS

WORK & TRADE

LIFE & DEATH

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

One city, many meanings

WORSHIP

- Evening Ganga aarti
- Kashi Vishwanath

LEARNING & ARTS

- Banaras Hindu University
- Hindustani music gharanas

WORK & TRADE

- Banarasi silk looms
- Boatmen ferrying visitors

LIFE & DEATH

- Cremation at Manikarnika ghat
- Hospices for the dying

ACTIVITY

From river to temple

Put these in the correct order.

- **A** Boat on the Ganga at dawn
- **B** Climb the ghat steps
- **C** Walk the narrow lanes
- **D** Darshan at Kashi Vishwanath
- **E** Pass security and leave shoes

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

From river to temple

1. Boat on the Ganga at dawn
2. Climb the ghat steps
3. Walk the narrow lanes
4. Pass security and leave shoes
5. Darshan at Kashi Vishwanath

Who built the present Kashi Vishwanath temple in 1780?

A Ashoka

B Queen Ahilyabai Holkar

C Rajaraja Chola

D Akbar

Why do many Hindus hope to die in Kashi?

- **A** For tax reasons
- **B** It is believed to grant moksha (liberation)
- **C** Medical care is free
- **D** It is the capital

What did the 2021 Kashi Vishwanath Corridor do?

A Moved the temple

B Built a dam

C Closed the ghats

D Linked the temple directly to the river ghats

What does the name Kashi mean?

- **A** City of light
- **B** Mountain city
- **C** City of rivers
- **D** Old town

QUIZ

Answers

1. **B. Queen Ahilyabai Holkar**

   She sponsored temples across India.

2. **B. It is believed to grant moksha (liberation)**

   An emic belief central to the city's identity.

3. **D. Linked the temple directly to the river ghats**

   It also raised heritage debates.

4. **A. City of light**

   Related to the Sanskrit for shining.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Argue in three sentences: should a sacred city prioritize pilgrims, residents or heritage? Acknowledge one counterargument.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, DECEMBER 6, 2026

Class 7: Prayagraj, Haridwar and the Kumbh Mela

Class 7

Prayagraj, Haridwar and the Kumbh Mela

PASSPORT SANGAM 2026-27

Sunday, December 6, 2026 · Unit 2: Sacred Rivers, Cities and Northern Routes

3 min Wonder | 7 min Learn | 3 min Map | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

How do you build, run and dismantle a temporary city for tens of millions?

List the systems a city needs in its first 24 hours.

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Prayagraj, Haridwar and the Kumbh Mela

Triveni Sangam

At Prayagraj the Ganga and Yamuna meet; tradition adds the unseen Saraswati. Bathing at confluences is considered especially meritorious.

Kumbh Mela

Rotates among Prayagraj, Haridwar, Ujjain and Nashik, timed by the positions of Jupiter, the sun and the moon. A story of drops of amrita (nectar) falling at these four places explains the cycle.

Scale and planning

The 2025 Maha Kumbh at Prayagraj was reported by officials as drawing hundreds of millions of visits over about six weeks, with tents, pontoon bridges, hospitals and sanitation built on the riverbed.

Heritage and risk

UNESCO inscribed the Kumbh Mela as Intangible Cultural Heritage in 2017. Crowd surges, including deadly ones, show the risks of extreme density.

LEARN

Key terms

sangam	SUNG-um	confluence
amrita	UM-ri-ta	nectar of immortality
akhara	a-KHAA-ra	order of ascetics
snan	SNAAN	ritual bath

MAP

Where in the world?



1. **Prayagraj** Uttar Pradesh
   Triveni Sangam: where the Ganga and Yamuna meet with, in tradition, the unseen Saraswati.

2. **Haridwar** Uttarakhand
   Where the Ganga leaves the mountains for the plains. Evening aarti at Har ki Pauri ghat.

3. **Ujjain (Mahakaleshwar)** Madhya Pradesh
   Mahakaleshwar Jyotirlinga on the Shipra river. One of the four Kumbh Mela cities.

4. **Nashik** Maharashtra
   Kumbh Mela city on the Godavari. Trimbakeshwar Jyotirlinga is nearby.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Prayagraj, Haridwar and the Kumbh Mela

WHOLE CLASS

Build a tabletop temporary city with cards for water, toilets, medical care, paths, food and waste.

YOUR TASK

You are on the planning committee. Prioritize the six systems with a limited budget and justify your top two. Identify one environmental and one safety trade-off.

DISCUSS

Who is responsible when a crowd disaster happens at a religious gathering: organizers, government, or no one? How can planning reduce risk?

ACTIVITY

Problem and system

Match each item on the left with one on the right.

1 Peak bathing-day crowd surge	A Clean water and sanitation
2 Lost children and elders	B Field hospitals
3 Tons of waste daily	C Lost-and-found centers
4 Waterborne disease risk	D Timed entry and one-way routes
5 Medical emergencies	E Pontoon bridges
6 Crossing a wide river	F Waste collection and segregation

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Problem and system

1 → D Peak bathing-day crowd surge — Timed entry and one-way routes

2 → C Lost children and elders — Lost-and-found centers

3 → F Tons of waste daily — Waste collection and segregation

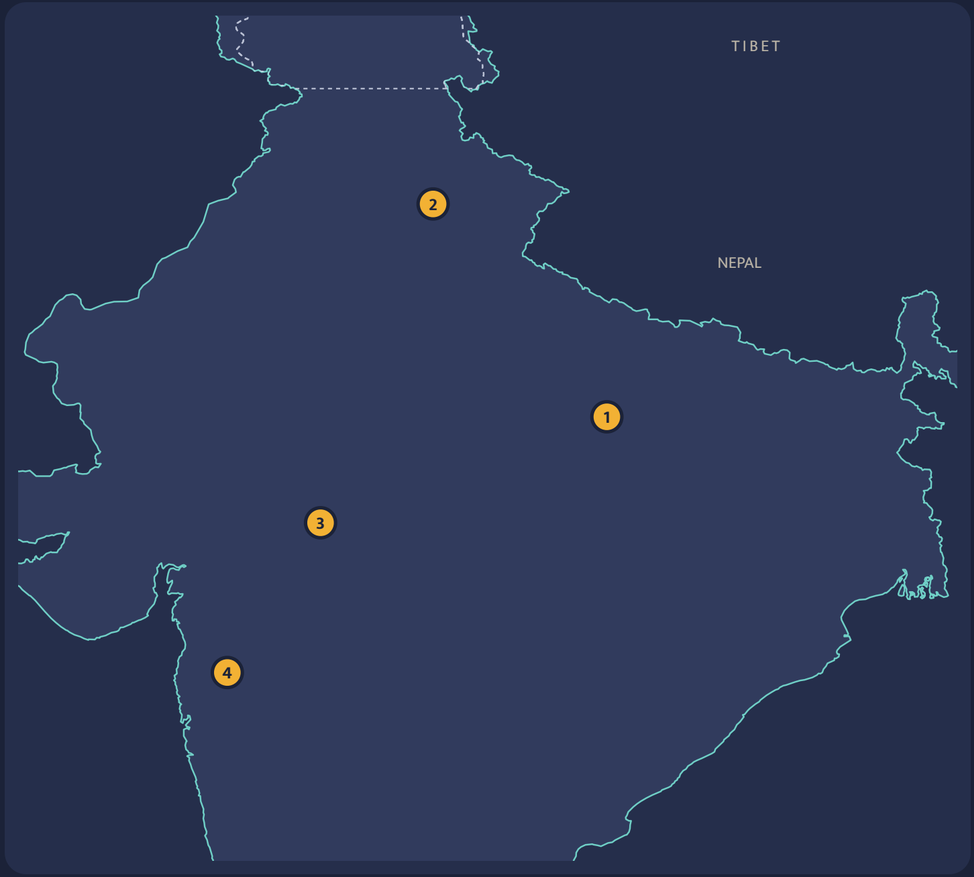
4 → A Waterborne disease risk — Clean water and sanitation

5 → B Medical emergencies — Field hospitals

6 → E Crossing a wide river — Pontoon bridges

ACTIVITY

The four Kumbh cities



Which number is each site?

- Prayagraj → ___
- Nashik → ___
- Ujjain (Mahakaleshwar) → ___
- Haridwar → ___

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

The four Kumbh cities

1. Prayagraj
2. Haridwar
3. Ujjain (Mahakaleshwar)
4. Nashik

What determines Kumbh Mela timing?

A. Positions of Jupiter, the sun and the moon

B. Government elections

C. Monsoon rainfall only

D. The school calendar

Which story explains the four Kumbh cities?

A Krishna’s birth

B The Mahabharata war

C Rama’s journey

D Drops of amrita falling at four places

When did UNESCO recognize the Kumbh Mela?

A 1947

B 2025

C 2017

D 1990

What are akharas?

A Rivers

B Police units

C Tent hotels

D Orders of ascetics who lead the royal baths

QUIZ

Answers

1. **A. Positions of Jupiter, the sun and the moon**

   Astrological reckoning sets the dates.

2. **D. Drops of amrita falling at four places**

   An emic explanation of the cycle.

3. **C. 2017**

   As Intangible Cultural Heritage.

4. **D. Orders of ascetics who lead the royal baths**

   Their processions are highlights of the Mela.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Name one joy and one danger of mass gatherings, and propose one evidence-based way to make them safer.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, DECEMBER 13, 2026

Class 8: Ayodhya, Mathura and Vrindavan

Class 8

Ayodhya, Mathura and Vrindavan

PASSPORT
BRAJ
2026–27

Sunday, December 13, 2026 · Unit 2: Sacred Rivers, Cities and Northern Routes

3 min Wonder | 7 min Learn | 3 min Map | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

What happens when a place is sacred because of a story?

How do people locate stories on real maps?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Ayodhya, Mathura and Vrindavan

Ayodhya

On the Sarayu river. In the Ramayana it is Rama's capital. Many families connect Diwali lamps with Rama's return home.

Mathura and Vrindavan

On the Yamuna in the Braj region. Many traditions honor Mathura as Krishna's birthplace and Vrindavan as the setting of his youth with the gopis and cowherds.

Mapping a sacred landscape

In the 16th century, followers of Chaitanya and Vallabhacharya identified and revived many Braj sites linked with Krishna stories, shaping pilgrimage routes still used today.

Narrative and history

Sacred narrative, archaeology and written records answer different questions. Some sites, including Ayodhya, have also been the focus of major legal and political disputes in modern India.

LEARN

Key terms

Braj	BRUJ	Krishna’s home region
parikrama	pa-ri-KRUH-maa	circling pilgrimage route
lila	LEE-laa	divine play
bhakti	BHUK-tee	devotion

MAP

Where in the world?



1. **Ayodhya** Uttar Pradesh
   City on the Sarayu river. In the Ramayana, Rama's home and capital.

2. **Mathura** Uttar Pradesh
   On the Yamuna. Many traditions honor it as Krishna's birthplace.

3. **Vrindavan** Uttar Pradesh
   Town of Krishna's childhood stories, full of temples and devotional songs.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Ayodhya, Mathura and Vrindavan

WHOLE CLASS

Place story events on the map of the Braj region and Ayodhya.

YOUR TASK

Compare a short devotional passage about Vrindavan with a historian's description of how Braj pilgrimage sites were identified. What does each emphasize, and what does each leave out?

DISCUSS

How should a classroom discuss sacred sites that are also politically contested, while staying accurate and respectful to everyone?

ACTIVITY

Place and story

Match each item on the left with one on the right.

1 Vrindavan	A Krishna lifts a hill to shelter villagers
2 Mathura	B River of Braj
3 Sarayu	C Krishna’s birth
4 Yamuna	D Krishna’s youth with the gopis
5 Ayodhya	E Rama’s capital and return
6 Govardhan	F River of Ayodhya

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Place and story

1 → D Vrindavan — Krishna's youth with the gopis

2 → C Mathura — Krishna's birth

3 → F Sarayu — River of Ayodhya

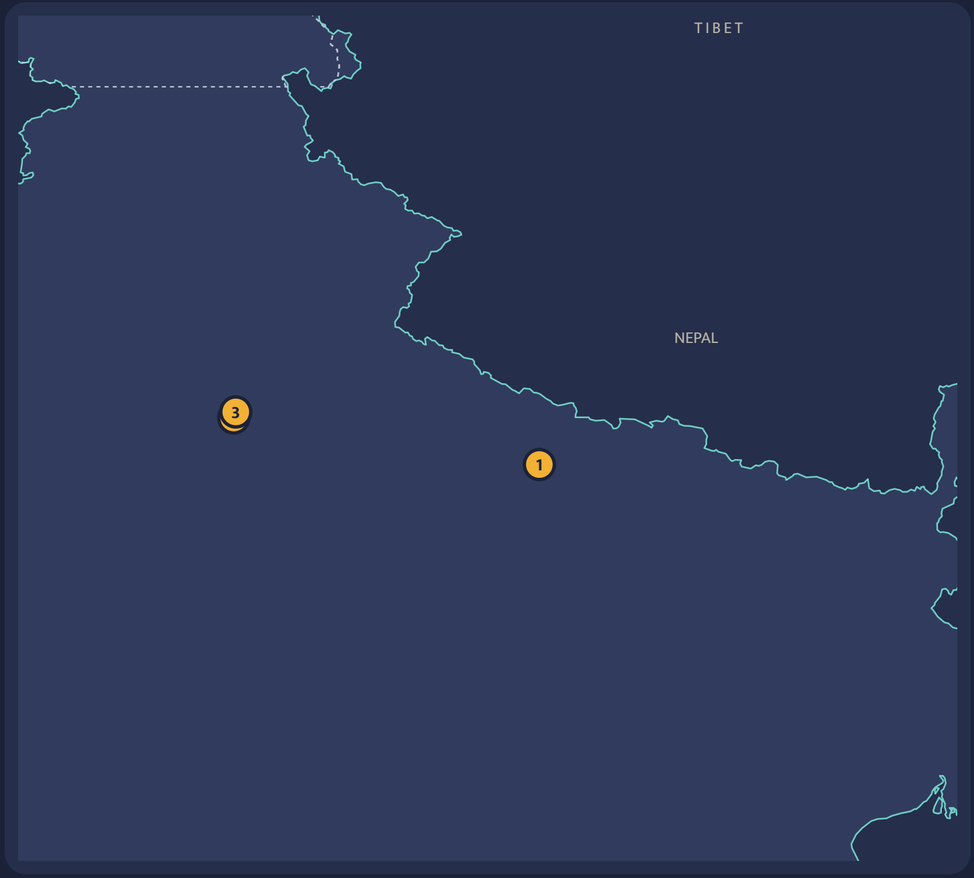
4 → B Yamuna — River of Braj

5 → E Ayodhya — Rama's capital and return

6 → A Govardhan — Krishna lifts a hill to shelter villagers

ACTIVITY

Find it on the map



Which number is each site?

Vrindavan → ___

Mathura → ___

Ayodhya → __

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Find it on the map

1 Ayodhya

2 Mathura

3 Vrindavan

Which 16th-century movements helped revive Braj pilgrimage sites?

A Followers of Chaitanya and Vallabhacharya

B The Mughal army

C British surveyors

D Jain monks

Mathura and Vrindavan lie on which river?

A Yamuna

B Sarayu

C Ganga

D Godavari

What does lila mean in Krishna devotion?

- **A** A tax
- **B** Divine play
- **C** A procession cart
- **D** A temple wall

The best approach to a contested sacred site in class is...

- **A** Avoid all facts
- **B** Repeat social media claims
- **C** Pick a side
- **D** Separate the narrative, the historical evidence and the modern dispute

QUIZ

Answers

1. **A. Followers of Chaitanya and Vallabhacharya**

   They identified sites linked to Krishna stories.

2. **A. Yamuna**

   The Braj region follows the Yamuna.

3. **B. Divine play**

   Stories of Krishna’s lila shape the landscape.

4. **D. Separate the narrative, the historical evidence and the modern dispute**

   Clear distinctions keep the discussion accurate.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Start Site Profile 1: choose a site and list three sources of different types you will use.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, JANUARY 10, 2027

Class 9–10: Himalayan Sacred Landscapes

Class 9–10

Himalayan Sacred Landscapes

Sunday, January 10, 2027 · Unit 2: Sacred Rivers, Cities and Northern Routes

PASSPORT HIMALAYA 2026–27

3 min Wonder | 7 min Learn | 3 min Map | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

What happens to a pilgrimage when its sacred places sit in fragile mountains across national borders?

Think about climate, politics and access.

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Himalayan Sacred Landscapes

The Chota Char Dham

Yamunotri, Gangotri, Kedarnath and Badrinath in Uttarakhand, traditionally visited west to east. Snow closes them in winter; worship moves to lower winter seats.

A fragile landscape

The 2013 Kedarnath flood killed thousands. Road widening, crowds and climate change raise questions about how many pilgrims these valleys can safely hold.

Kailash and Manasarovar

In Tibet (China). Sacred to Hindus, Buddhists, Jains and Bon followers. Pilgrims walk the roughly 52 km circuit; access depends on permits and India–China relations.

Pashupatinath

A major Shiva temple on the Bagmati river in Kathmandu, Nepal, part of the Kathmandu Valley World Heritage Site.

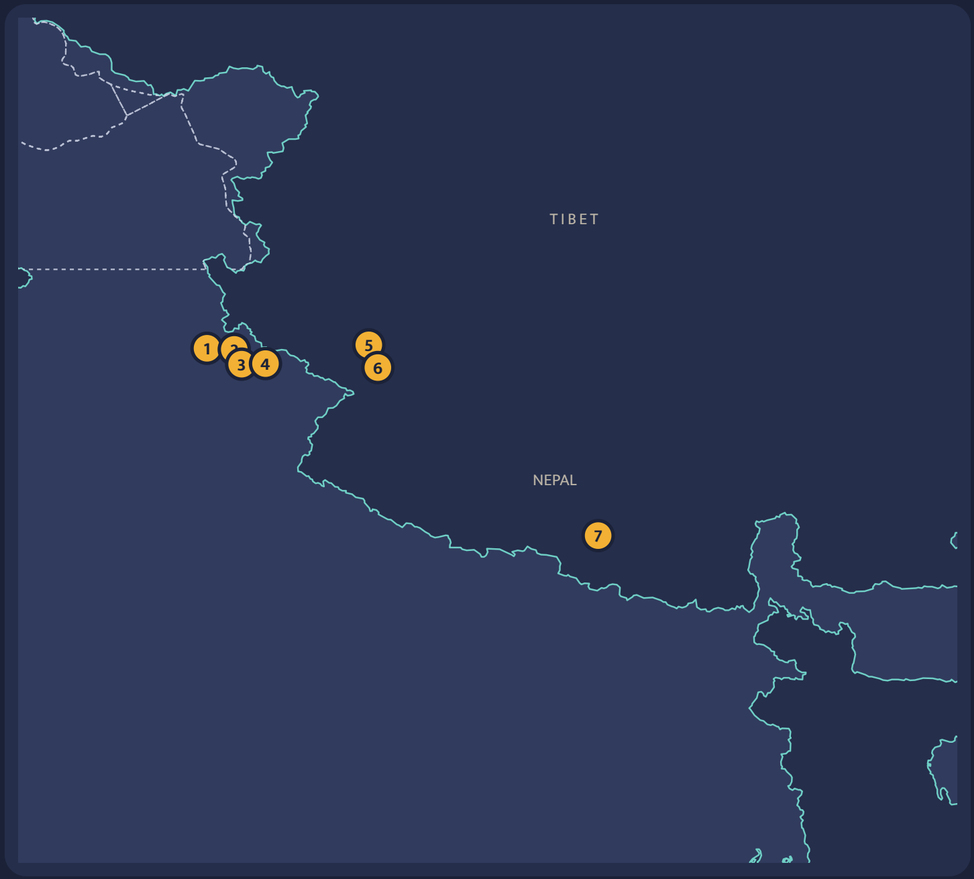
LEARN

Key terms

dham	DHAAM	abode; holy seat
kora / parikrama	KOR-a	circumambulation route
carrying capacity	—	how many visitors a place can safely support

MAP

Where in the world?



1 **Yamunotri** Uttarakhand

Temple of Goddess Yamuna, near the source of the Yamuna river.

2 **Gangotri** Uttarakhand

Temple of Goddess Ganga, near the glacier where the river begins.

3 **Kedarnath** Uttarakhand

Shiva temple at about 3,580 m. One of the 12 Jyotirlingas.

4 **Badrinath** Uttarakhand

Vishnu temple (Badrinarayan) on the Alaknanda river. Part of both Char Dham circuits.

5 **Mount Kailash** Tibet (China)

Mountain linked with Shiva. Pilgrims walk around it (about 52 km) instead of climbing it.

6 **Lake Manasarovar** Tibet (China)

High-altitude lake near Kailash, honored in Hindu, Buddhist and Jain traditions.

7 **Pashupatinath** Kathmandu, Nepal

Shiva temple on the Bagmati river, part of the Kathmandu Valley World Heritage Site.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Himalayan Sacred Landscapes

WHOLE CLASS

Trace the Chota Char Dham on the relief map, then add the sites across the borders.

YOUR TASK

Design a low-impact itinerary for the Chota Char Dham using elevation and season. Propose one policy (permits, caps, transport) to protect the valleys, and name who would object.

DISCUSS

Should governments cap the number of pilgrims at sacred mountain sites? Who should decide?

ACTIVITY

Chota Char Dham, west to east

Put these in the correct order.

A Gangotri

B Kedarnath

C Badrinath

D Yamunotri

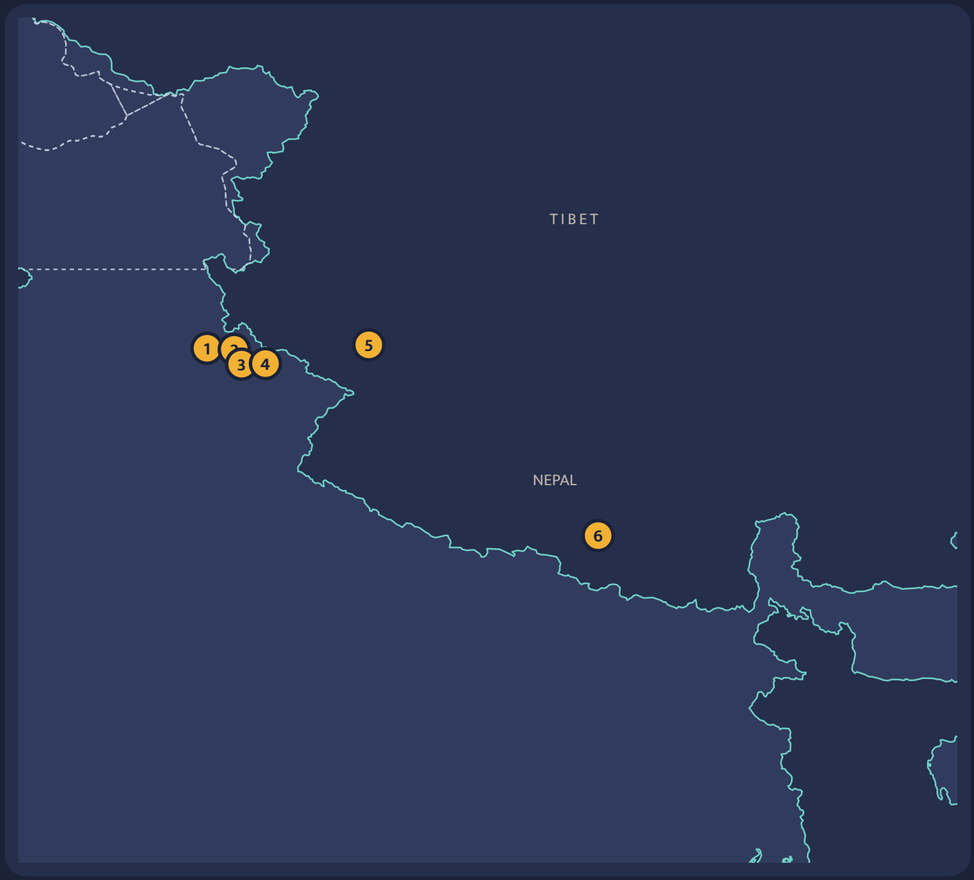
ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Chota Char Dham, west to east

1. Yamunotri
2. Gangotri
3. Kedarnath
4. Badrinath

ACTIVITY

Himalayan map game



Which number is each site?

Gangotri → ___

Mount Kailash → ___

Yamunotri → ___

Pashupatinath → ___

Badrinath → ___

Kedarnath → ___

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Himalayan map game

1 Yamunotri

2 Gangotri

3 Kedarnath

4 Badrinath

5 Mount Kailash

6 Pashupatinath

QUIZ · QUESTION 1 OF 4

What disaster in 2013 reshaped debate about Himalayan pilgrimage?

A An earthquake in Delhi

B A cyclone in Gujarat

C A drought in Kerala

D The Kedarnath flood

Why can access to Kailash change from year to year?

A It is underwater

B It is privately owned

C It moves

D It depends on permits and India–China relations

Which traditions hold Kailash sacred?

A. Hindu, Buddhist, Jain and Bon

B. Only Hindu

C. Only Bon

D. None

What is “carrying capacity”?

- **A** How many visitors a place can safely support
- **B** A temple tax
- **C** Bus seating
- **D** The weight a mule can carry

QUIZ

Answers

1. **D. The Kedarnath flood**

   Thousands died in the flash floods.

2. **D. It depends on permits and India–China relations**

   Borders shape sacred journeys.

3. **A. Hindu, Buddhist, Jain and Bon**

   A shared sacred landscape.

4. **A. How many visitors a place can safely support**

   A key idea in sustainable tourism.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Turn in Site Profile 1. Write one paragraph: how do environment and borders shape Himalayan pilgrimage?

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, JANUARY 24, 2027

Class 11: The All-India Char Dham

Class 11

The All-India Char Dham

Sunday, January 24, 2027 · Unit 3: Pan-Indian Circuits and Major Traditions



3 min Wonder | 7 min Learn | 3 min Map | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

Can a pilgrimage route create a sense of one shared land?

What does it mean to travel to all four edges of a country?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

The All-India Char Dham

Four directions

Badrinath (north), Dwarka (west), Puri (east) and Rameswaram (south) mark the edges of the subcontinent.

Adi Shankaracharya

Tradition credits this 8th-century philosopher of Advaita Vedanta with founding monasteries (mathas) in four directions, linking the circuit to a pan-Indian network.

Diversity within unity

The circuit joins Vaishnava sites (Badrinath, Dwarka, Puri) with a Shaiva one (Rameswaram), linked to Rama. Languages, foods and rituals differ at each.

Pilgrimage and nation

Historians argue such circuits helped people imagine India as a connected sacred space long before the modern nation-state.

LEARN

Key terms

matha	MUTT	monastery
Advaita	ad-VAI-ta	non-dual philosophy
Vaishnava / Shaiva	VAISH-na-va / SHAI-va	devoted to Vishnu / Shiva

MAP

Where in the world?



1 **Badrinath** Uttarakhand

Vishnu temple (Badrinarayan) on the Alaknanda river. Part of both Char Dham circuits.

2 **Dwarka** Gujarat

Western Char Dham. Dwarkadhish temple of Krishna beside the Arabian Sea.

3 **Puri** Odisha

Eastern Char Dham. Jagannath temple and the Rath Yatra chariot festival.

4 **Rameswaram** Tamil Nadu

Island temple town. Southern Char Dham with very long pillared corridors.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

The All-India Char Dham

WHOLE CLASS

Place the four dhams on a compass map and complete the deity–landscape–food–festival puzzle.

YOUR TASK

Compare the all-India Char Dham with the Himalayan Chota Char Dham: purpose, geography, deities and who can realistically complete each.

DISCUSS

Do pilgrimage circuits unify a diverse country, or can they also exclude people? Give examples.

ACTIVITY

Which direction?

Place each card in a group.

Badrinath | Rameswaram | Puri | Dwarka

NORTH	WEST	EAST	SOUTH

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Which direction?

NORTH

Badrinath

WEST

Dwarka

EAST

Puri

SOUTH

Rameswaram

ACTIVITY

Site, deity, setting

Match each item on the left with one on the right.

1 Dwarka	A Vishnu, Himalayan valley
2 Rameswaram	B Jagannath, Bay of Bengal coast
3 Badrinath	C Shiva, island in the Gulf of Mannar
4 Puri	D Krishna, Arabian Sea coast

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Site, deity, setting

1 → D Dwarka — Krishna, Arabian Sea coast

2 → C Rameswaram — Shiva, island in the Gulf of Mannar

3 → A Badrinath — Vishnu, Himalayan valley

4 → B Puri — Jagannath, Bay of Bengal coast

Which philosopher does tradition link with the four dhams?

A Kabir

B Ramanuja

C Adi Shankaracharya

D Tulsidas

QUIZ · QUESTION 2 OF 4

Which dham honors Shiva?

A Badrinath

B Puri

C Dwarka

D Rameswaram

Historians argue such circuits helped people…

A. Build railways

B. Avoid travel

C. Collect taxes

D. Imagine a connected sacred land

How does it differ from the Chota Char Dham?

A. It spans all four directions of India

B. It has no temples

C. It is all in one state

D. It is only for priests

QUIZ

Answers

1. **C. Adi Shankaracharya**

   Associated with four mathas.

2. **D. Rameswaram**

   Its deity is Ramanathaswamy.

3. **D. Imagine a connected sacred land**

   Long before the modern nation-state.

4. **A. It spans all four directions of India**

   The Chota Char Dham is in Uttarakhand.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Explain in one paragraph what connects the four dhams beyond geography.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, JANUARY 31, 2027

Class 12: Shiva and the Jyotirlinga Network

Class 12

Shiva and the Jyotirlinga Network

PASSPORT JYOTI 2026-27

Sunday, January 31, 2027 · Unit 3: Pan-Indian Circuits and Major Traditions

3 min Wonder | 7 min Learn | 3 min Map | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

Why would a tradition count exactly twelve sacred sites, and what happens when communities disagree on the list?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Shiva and the Jyotirlinga Network

Linga of light

A story tells of Shiva appearing as an endless pillar of light; Brahma and Vishnu could not find its ends. Jyotirlinga means “linga of light.”

Twelve sites

Twelve Jyotirlingas span India. A widely recited Sanskrit hymn lists them, and many pilgrims aim to visit all twelve.

Somnath

On the Gujarat coast. Raided by Mahmud of Ghazni in 1026 and rebuilt many times; the present temple was completed in 1951 and became a symbol in post-independence India.

Contested lists

For a few Jyotirlingas, more than one temple claims the title, e.g. Vaidyanath (Deoghar in Jharkhand or Parli in Maharashtra) and Nageshwar. Local identity and pride are at stake.

LEARN

Key terms

linga	LING-a	aniconic form of Shiva
aniconic	an-eye-KON-ik	not shaped like a figure
Mahakaleshwar	ma-haa-kaa-LAYSH-war	Shiva as lord of time, Ujjain

MAP

Where in the world?



1 **Somnath** Gujarat

Seaside Jyotirlinga temple, rebuilt many times. The present temple dates from 1951.

2 **Varanasi (Kashi)** Uttar Pradesh

Ancient city on the Ganga with stone ghats and the Kashi Vishwanath temple of Shiva.

3 **Ujjain (Mahakaleshwar)** Madhya Pradesh

Mahakaleshwar Jyotirlinga on the Shipra river. One of the four Kumbh Mela cities.

4 **Kedarnath** Uttarakhand

Shiva temple at about 3,580 m. One of the 12 Jyotirlingas.

5 **Rameswaram** Tamil Nadu

Island temple town. Southern Char Dham with very long pillared corridors.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Shiva and the Jyotirlinga Network

WHOLE CLASS

Connect five Jyotirlinga sites with yarn on the map and note the landscapes.

YOUR TASK

Investigate one contested Jyotirlinga claim. Identify the competing sites, the evidence each community cites, and explain why the dispute matters locally.

DISCUSS

Somnath has been destroyed and rebuilt many times. Is a rebuilt temple the same sacred place?

ACTIVITY

Coast, river or mountain?

Place each card in a group.

Kashi Vishwanath

Mahakaleshwar (Shipra river)

Ramanathaswamy, Rameswaram

Somnath

Kedarnath

SEACOAST

RIVERBANK

MOUNTAINS

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Coast, river or mountain?

SEACOAST

- Somnath
- Ramanathaswamy, Rameswaram

RIVERBANK

- Kashi Vishwanath
- Mahakaleshwar (Shipra river)

MOUNTAINS

- Kedarnath

ACTIVITY

Find the Jyotirlingas



Which number is each site?

- Ujjain (Mahakaleshwar) → ___
- Kedarnath → ___
- Rameswaram → ___
- Somnath → ___
- Varanasi (Kashi) → ___

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Find the Jyotirlingas

1. Somnath
2. Varanasi (Kashi)
3. Ujjain (Mahakaleshwar)
4. Kedarnath
5. Rameswaram

What does aniconic mean?

A. Not shaped like a human or animal figure

B. Very large

C. Made of wood

D. Painted gold

When was the present Somnath temple completed?

A 2001

B 1951

C 1026

D 1780

Which Jyotirlinga has rival claimants in Jharkhand and Maharashtra?

A Vaidyanath

B Somnath

C Kedarnath

D Kashi Vishwanath

Mahakaleshwar is in which city?

A Ujjain

B Mysuru

C Patna

D Pune

QUIZ

Answers

1. **A. Not shaped like a human or animal figure**

   The linga is an aniconic form.

2. **B. 1951**

   It became a symbol after independence.

3. **A. Vaidyanath**

   Deoghar and Parli both claim it.

4. **A. Ujjain**

   On the Shipra river.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Argue whether a rebuilt temple is the same sacred place. Use Somnath as evidence.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 7, 2027

Class 13: Shakti Peethas and Goddess Traditions

Class 13

Shakti Peethas and Goddess Traditions

PASSPORT SHAKTI 2026–27

Sunday, February 7, 2027 · Unit 3: Pan-Indian Circuits and Major Traditions

3 min Wonder | **7** min Learn | **3** min Map | **9** min Explore | **5** min Quiz | **3** min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

What can goddess traditions tell us about how power and the divine are imagined?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Shakti Peethas and Goddess Traditions

Shakti and Devi

Shakti means power or energy. Shakta traditions worship the Goddess (Devi) as supreme, in forms from fierce (Kali, Durga) to nurturing (Lakshmi, Parvati).

The Shakti Peetha story

Sati's death and Shiva's grief scatter her body across the land; each place becomes a seat (peetha) of the Goddess. Texts give 4, 18, 51, 52 or 108 sites.

Case studies

Kamakhya (Guwahati) is a major Tantric center; Kalighat (Kolkata) honors Kali; Vaishno Devi is a mountain cave shrine in Jammu; Kamakshi Amman is in Kanchipuram.

Mapping power

The story turns the whole subcontinent into the Goddess's body. Scholars read this as a way of uniting distant regional goddesses into one network.

LEARN

Key terms

Shakta	SHAAK-ta	devotee of the Goddess
peetha	PEE-tha	seat
Tantra	TUN-tra	ritual and esoteric tradition

MAP

Where in the world?



1 **Kamakhya** Assam

Goddess temple on Nilachal Hill above the Brahmaputra, in Guwahati.

2 **Kalighat** West Bengal

Temple of Kali in Kolkata, beside an old channel of the Hooghly river.

3 **Vaishno Devi** Jammu & Kashmir

Cave shrine of the Goddess in the Trikuta mountains, reached by a long uphill walk from Katra.

4 **Kanchipuram** Tamil Nadu

Temple town of Kamakshi Amman, also famous for silk weaving.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Shakti Peethas and Goddess Traditions

WHOLE CLASS

Compare images, landscapes and community descriptions of the four shrines.

YOUR TASK

Compare two Shakti Peetha lists from different texts or traditions. Explain at least two reasons lists differ (region, sect, era, politics of pilgrimage).

DISCUSS

What does it mean for a land to be imagined as a goddess's body? Compare with other traditions that sanctify land.

ACTIVITY

Shrine and setting

Match each item on the left with one on the right.

1 Kalighat	A Cave shrine in the Trikuta mountains
2 Kamakshi Amman	B Kolkata, beside the old Hooghly channel
3 Vaishno Devi	C Hilltop above the Brahmaputra, Tantric center
4 Kamakhya	D Temple town of Kanchipuram

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Shrine and setting

1 → B Kalighat — Kolkata, beside the old Hooghly channel

2 → D Kamakshi Amman — Temple town of Kanchipuram

3 → A Vaishno Devi — Cave shrine in the Trikuta mountains

4 → C Kamakhya — Hilltop above the Brahmaputra, Tantric center

ACTIVITY

Find the Goddess shrines



Which number is each site?

Vaishno Devi → ___

Kalighat → ___

Kamakhya → ___

Kanchipuram → ___

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Find the Goddess shrines

1 Kamakhya

2 Kalighat

3 Vaishno Devi

4 Kanchipuram

Shakta traditions treat the Goddess as...

- **A** Supreme divine power
- **B** A historical queen
- **C** A river only
- **D** A minor helper

Why do Shakti Peetha counts vary (4 to 108)?

A They don’t vary

B Different texts, regions and sects list different sites

C Temples move

D Typos

Which shrine is a major Tantric center?

A Kalighat

B Vaishno Devi

C Kamakhya

D Kamakshi Amman

How do scholars read the scattered-body story?

- **A** As a battle record
- **B** As a recipe
- **C** As linking regional goddesses into one network
- **D** As a medical text

QUIZ

Answers

1. **A. Supreme divine power**

   Shakti is the ultimate reality.

2. **B. Different texts, regions and sects list different sites**

   Diversity within one tradition.

3. **C. Kamakhya**

   On Nilachal Hill in Guwahati.

4. **C. As linking regional goddesses into one network**

   Geography becomes theology.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Answer: what does diversity within one tradition look like? Use evidence from today.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 21, 2027

Class 14: Vishnu and Krishna Pilgrimage Centers

Class 14

Vishnu and Krishna Pilgrimage Centers

Sunday, February 21, 2027 · Unit 3: Pan-Indian Circuits and Major Traditions

PASSPORT SEVA 2026–27

3 min Wonder | 7 min Learn | 3 min Map | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

Is a large temple more like a place of worship, a city government or a business?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Vishnu and Krishna Pilgrimage Centers

Tirumala-Tirupati

Hilltop shrine of Venkateswara, among the most visited and wealthiest temples in the world. Run by the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD), which also funds schools and hospitals.

Srirangam

Ranganathaswamy temple on an island between the Kaveri and Kollidam rivers, with seven concentric enclosures; a center of the Sri Vaishnava tradition associated with Ramanuja.

Puri and Guruvayur

Puri's kitchen cooks mahaprasad in clay pots over wood fires for thousands daily. Guruvayur in Kerala keeps a herd of temple elephants.

Temples as institutions

Many large temples in India are managed by state-appointed boards. Who should control temple funds is an ongoing public debate.

LEARN

Key terms

Devasthanam	day-vu-STHAA-num	temple trust
hundi	HOON-dee	offering box
Sri Vaishnava	SHREE VAISH-na-va	South Indian Vishnu tradition

MAP

Where in the world?



1 **Tirumala-Tirupati** Andhra Pradesh

Hilltop temple of Venkateswara, one of the most visited temples in the world.

2 **Srirangam** Tamil Nadu

Ranganathaswamy temple on an island in the Kaveri river.

3 **Dwarka** Gujarat

Western Char Dham. Dwarkadhish temple of Krishna beside the Arabian Sea.

4 **Puri** Odisha

Eastern Char Dham. Jagannath temple and the Rath Yatra chariot festival.

5 **Guruvayur** Kerala

Krishna temple (Guruvayurappan) known for its elephants and music.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Vishnu and Krishna Pilgrimage Centers

WHOLE CLASS

Explore how a temple is a worship space, kitchen, workplace, archive and community center.

YOUR TASK

Create a systems diagram of a large temple: inputs (donations, food, volunteers), processes and outputs (meals, schools, festivals, records). Identify one point of tension.

DISCUSS

Should temples be managed by governments, independent trusts or devotee communities? Weigh accountability and autonomy.

ACTIVITY

Temple roles

Match each item on the left with one on the right.

1 Kitchen staff	A Performs daily rituals
2 Temple board	B Prepare prasad and free meals
3 Nadaswaram players	C Music for rituals and processions
4 Mahout	D Manages funds and administration
5 Archaka (priest)	E Crowd guidance and food service
6 Volunteers	F Cares for temple elephants

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Temple roles

1 → B Kitchen staff — Prepare prasad and free meals

2 → D Temple board — Manages funds and administration

3 → C Nadaswaram players — Music for rituals and processions

4 → F Mahout — Cares for temple elephants

5 → A Archaka (priest) — Performs daily rituals

6 → E Volunteers — Crowd guidance and food service

ACTIVITY

Find the temples



Which number is each site?

- Dwarka → ___
- Puri → ___
- Guruvayur → ___
- Srirangam → ___
- Tirumala-Tirupati → ___

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Find the temples

1. Tirumala-Tirupati
2. Srirangam
3. Dwarka
4. Puri
5. Guruvayur

What is the TTD?

- **A** A railway
- **B** A dance school
- **C** A political party
- **D** The trust that manages the Tirumala temple

Srirangam is closely associated with which teacher?

A Ramanuja

B Chaitanya

C Kabir

D Adi Shankaracharya

What is a hundi?

A. A gopuram

B. A drum

C. A vow

D. A temple offering box

QUIZ · QUESTION 4 OF 4

What debate surrounds many large temples?

- **A** Who should control temple funds
- **B** Building height only
- **C** None
- **D** Whether to use electricity

QUIZ

Answers

1. **D. The trust that manages the Tirumala temple**

   It runs schools and hospitals too.

2. **A. Ramanuja**

   A center of Sri Vaishnavism.

3. **D. A temple offering box**

   Donations fund temple operations.

4. **A. Who should control temple funds**

   Government vs. community management.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Begin Site Profile 2. Include a systems diagram for your chosen site.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 28, 2027

Class 15: Festivals that Move the Deity

Class 15

Festivals that Move the Deity

Sunday, February 28, 2027 · Unit 3: Pan-Indian Circuits and Major Traditions

PASSPORT
RATH
2026–27

3 min Wonder | 7 min Learn | 3 min Map | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

What changes when the sacred leaves the temple and enters public streets?

Who gains access, and who manages the crowd?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Festivals that Move the Deity

Rath Yatra, Puri

Jagannath, Balabhadra and Subhadra ride three wooden chariots, rebuilt every year, pulled by crowds to the Gundicha temple. The English word “juggernaut” comes from Jagannath.

Chithirai Festival, Madurai

Re-enacts the wedding of Meenakshi and Sundareswarar and joins it with Kallazhagar’s procession to the Vaigai, uniting Shaiva and Vaishnava festivals.

Karthigai Deepam

A great lamp is lit atop Arunachala hill at Tiruvannamalai, linked to Shiva as a column of fire.

Pandharpur Wari

Warkaris walk about 250 km over roughly three weeks to Pandharpur, carrying palkhis of the saints Dnyaneshwar and Tukaram and singing their abhangs. The Wari is open to all castes.

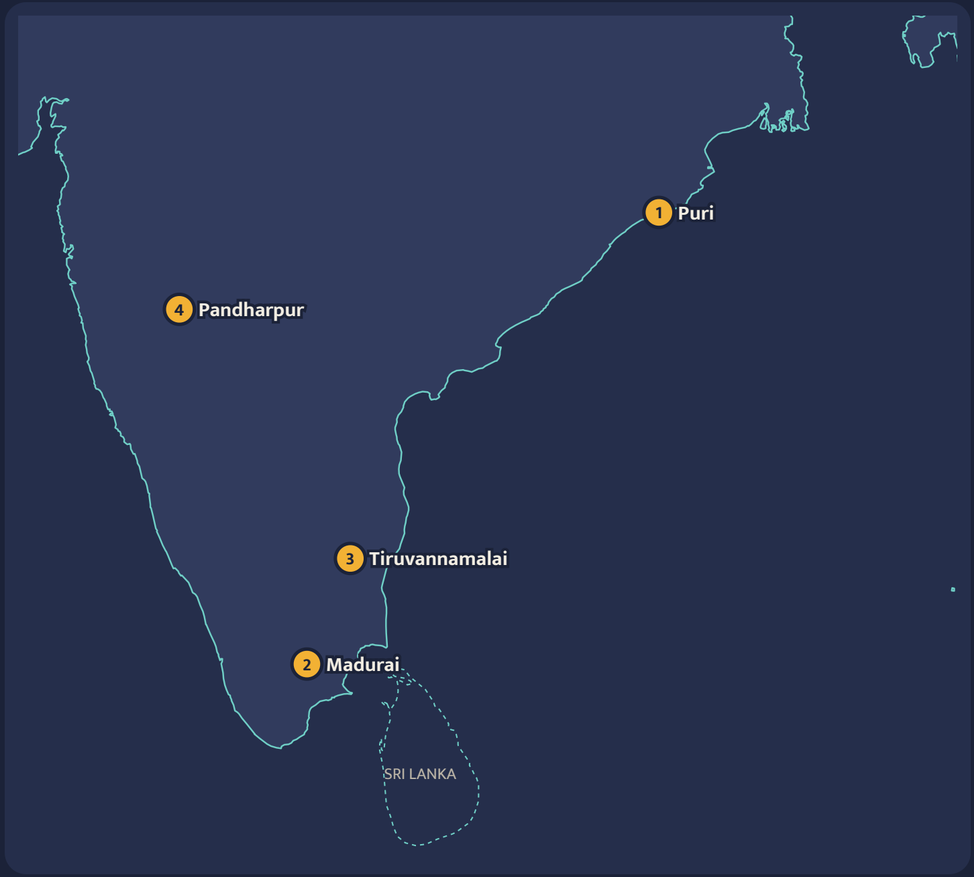
LEARN

Key terms

rath	RUTH	chariot
palkhi	PAAL-khee	palanquin
abhang	a-BHUNG	Marathi devotional song
Warkari	WAAR-ka-ree	Wari pilgrim

MAP

Where in the world?



1. **Puri** Odisha
   Eastern Char Dham. Jagannath temple and the Rath Yatra chariot festival.

2. **Madurai** Tamil Nadu
   Meenakshi Amman temple at the heart of a city on the Vaigai river.

3. **Tiruvannamalai** Tamil Nadu
   Arunachaleswarar temple. A great lamp is lit on the hill for Karthigai Deepam.

4. **Pandharpur** Maharashtra
   Vitthal temple on the Bhima river; end point of the Wari walk.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Festivals that Move the Deity

WHOLE CLASS

Storyboard one festival route from start to finish.

YOUR TASK

Plan crowd management for one festival: route, entry points, medical stations, communications. Then explain the festival’s meaning in two sentences.

DISCUSS

Why might it matter that the Wari welcomes everyone regardless of caste? What does a procession say about who belongs?

ACTIVITY

Festival and feature

Match each item on the left with one on the right.

1 Rath Yatra	A A divine wedding joined with a river procession
2 Chithirai Festival	B Three wooden chariots rebuilt yearly
3 Karthigai Deepam	C A three-week walk singing abhangs
4 Pandharpur Wari	D A great lamp on Arunachala hill

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Festival and feature

1 → B Rath Yatra — Three wooden chariots rebuilt yearly

2 → A Chithirai Festival — A divine wedding joined with a river procession

3 → D Karthigai Deepam — A great lamp on Arunachala hill

4 → C Pandharpur Wari — A three-week walk singing abhangs

ACTIVITY

Festival map



Which number is each site?

- Madurai → __
- Tiruvannamalai → __
- Pandharpur → __
- Puri → __

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Festival map

1 Puri

2 Madurai

3 Tiruvannamalai

4 Pandharpur

Which English word comes from Jagannath?

A Juggernaut

B Jungle

C Jaguar

D Journey

Which saints' palkhis lead the Wari?

A Mirabai and Surdas

B Basava and Allama

C Dnyaneshwar and Tukaram

D Tulsidas and Kabir

What does the Chithirai Festival unite?

A Two languages

B Two states

C Shaiva and Vaishnava festivals

D Hindu and Christian holidays

Why is the Wari socially significant?

A. It excludes women

B. It is open to people of all castes

C. It is only for priests

D. It is held online

QUIZ

Answers

1. **A. Juggernaut**

   Through European accounts of the chariots.

2. **C. Dnyaneshwar and Tukaram**

   Marathi bhakti saints.

3. **C. Shaiva and Vaishnava festivals**

   Meenakshi’s wedding and Kallazhagar’s journey.

4. **B. It is open to people of all castes**

   Bhakti emphasized devotion over status.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Explain why a sacred image might travel outside a temple, and what that reveals about community.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, MARCH 7, 2027

Class 16: Madurai Meenakshi and the Temple-City

Class 16

Madurai Meenakshi and the Temple-City

PASSPORT GOPURAM 2026–27

Sunday, March 7, 2027 · Unit 4: Southern and Western Temple Landscapes

3 min Wonder | 7 min Learn | 3 min Map | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

What if a city's street plan were designed around a temple's festival calendar?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Madurai Meenakshi and the Temple-City

The temple

Meenakshi Amman temple honors Meenakshi (a form of Parvati) and Sundareswarar (Shiva). Much of the present complex dates from the Nayak period (16th–17th c.).

Gopurams

Fourteen gateway towers covered in painted stucco figures; the tallest exceed 50 m. They are repainted during periodic renovations.

A mandala city

Old Madurai is laid out in concentric square streets named after Tamil months. Festivals process along the street named for their month.

Temple and economy

The Golden Lotus Tank and Thousand Pillar Hall sit inside; flower, cloth and brass markets fill the streets outside. Worship and commerce reinforce each other.

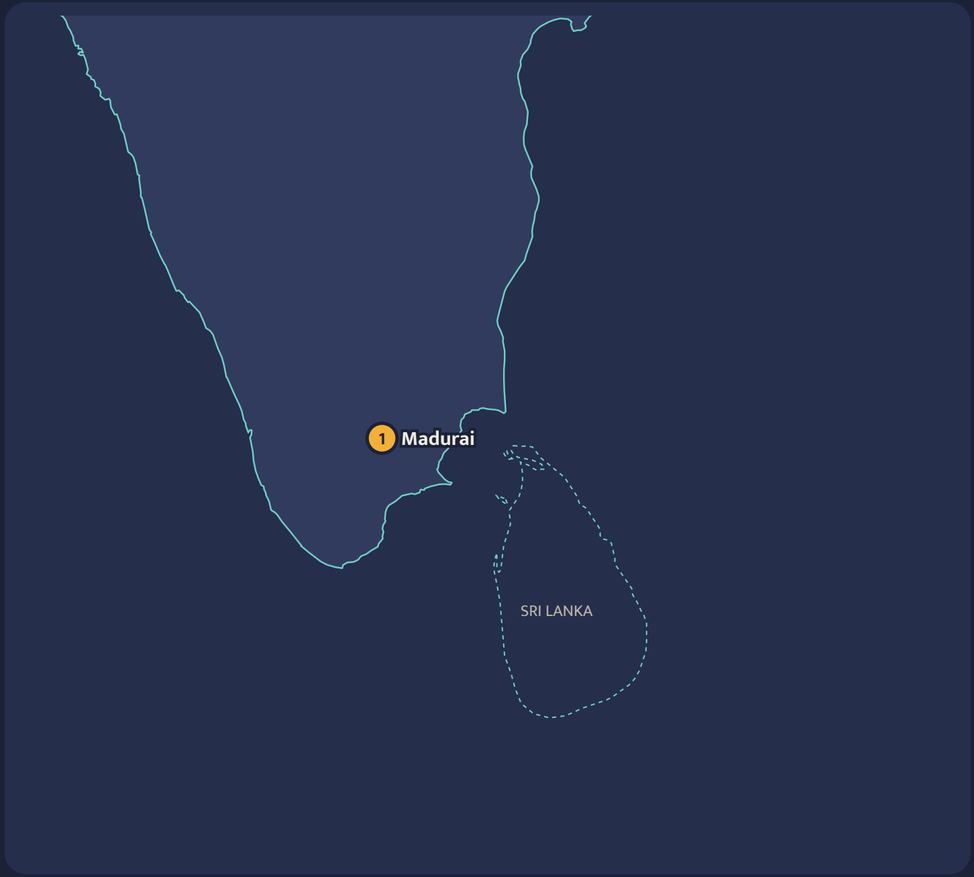
LEARN

Key terms

Nayak	NAA-yuk	dynasty that expanded the temple
mandala	MUN-da-la	sacred concentric diagram
kulam	KU-lam	temple tank

MAP

Where in the world?



1 **Madurai** Tamil Nadu

Meenakshi Amman temple at the heart of a city on the Vaigai river.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Madurai Meenakshi and the Temple-City

WHOLE CLASS

Trace walls, gateways, markets and procession streets on the city map.

YOUR TASK

Explain how Madurai's plan supports both worship and business. Then compare it with a planned city you know (e.g., Washington, D.C.).

DISCUSS

What is lost and gained when a living temple-city becomes a major tourist destination?

ACTIVITY

Gopuram builder

Use the Gopuram Builder in the interactive presentation, or sketch a gopuram from repeating tiers: wider at the base, narrowing to a barrel-shaped crown, every tier crowded with figures.

ACTIVITY

Inside the walls or the streets?

Place each card in a group.

Meenakshi’s shrine

Thousand Pillar Hall

Golden Lotus Tank

Flower markets

Tailors and brass shops

Month-named procession streets

INSIDE THE TEMPLE

CITY STREETS AROUND IT

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Inside the walls or the streets?

INSIDE THE TEMPLE

- Golden Lotus Tank
- Thousand Pillar Hall
- Meenakshi’s shrine

CITY STREETS AROUND IT

- Month-named procession streets
- Flower markets
- Tailors and brass shops

QUIZ · QUESTION 1 OF 4

Which dynasty built much of the present Meenakshi temple?

A The Mauryas

B The British

C The Mughals

D The Nayaks

Madurai's street names come from...

A Rivers

B Numbers

C Kings

D Tamil months

Gopuram figures are made of…

A Glass

B Wood

C Painted stucco

D Gold

QUIZ · QUESTION 4 OF 4

The city plan resembles a…

- **A** Grid of numbered avenues
- **B** Spiral
- **C** Random maze
- **D** Mandala of concentric squares

QUIZ

Answers

1. **D. The Nayaks**

   16th–17th centuries.

2. **D. Tamil months**

   Each street hosts that month's festival.

3. **C. Painted stucco**

   Repainted during renovations.

4. **D. Mandala of concentric squares**

   The temple sits at the center.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Identify three design features of a gopuram and explain what each communicates to a visitor.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, MARCH 14, 2027

Class 17: Thanjavur, Chidambaram and Temple Arts

Class 17

Thanjavur, Chidambaram and Temple Arts

PASSPORT NATARAJA 2026-27

Sunday, March 14, 2027 · Unit 4: Southern and Western Temple Landscapes

3 min Wonder | 7 min Learn | 3 min Map | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

How can art be devotion, history and royal propaganda all at once?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Thanjavur, Chidambaram and Temple Arts

Brihadisvara, Thanjavur

Completed around 1010 CE by Rajaraja I. Its granite vimana rises about 66 m. Part of the UNESCO Great Living Chola Temples.

Inscriptions as archive

Its walls record royal gifts, land grants, hundreds of temple dancers and staff, and their pay: a rare window into an 11th-century institution.

Nataraja

At Chidambaram Shiva is worshipped as Nataraja, Lord of the Dance. The cosmic dance (ananda tandava) represents creation, preservation, destruction, concealment and grace.

Chola bronzes

Cast by the lost-wax method, Chola bronzes were carried in processions. Many are now in museums worldwide, and some looted pieces have been returned to India.

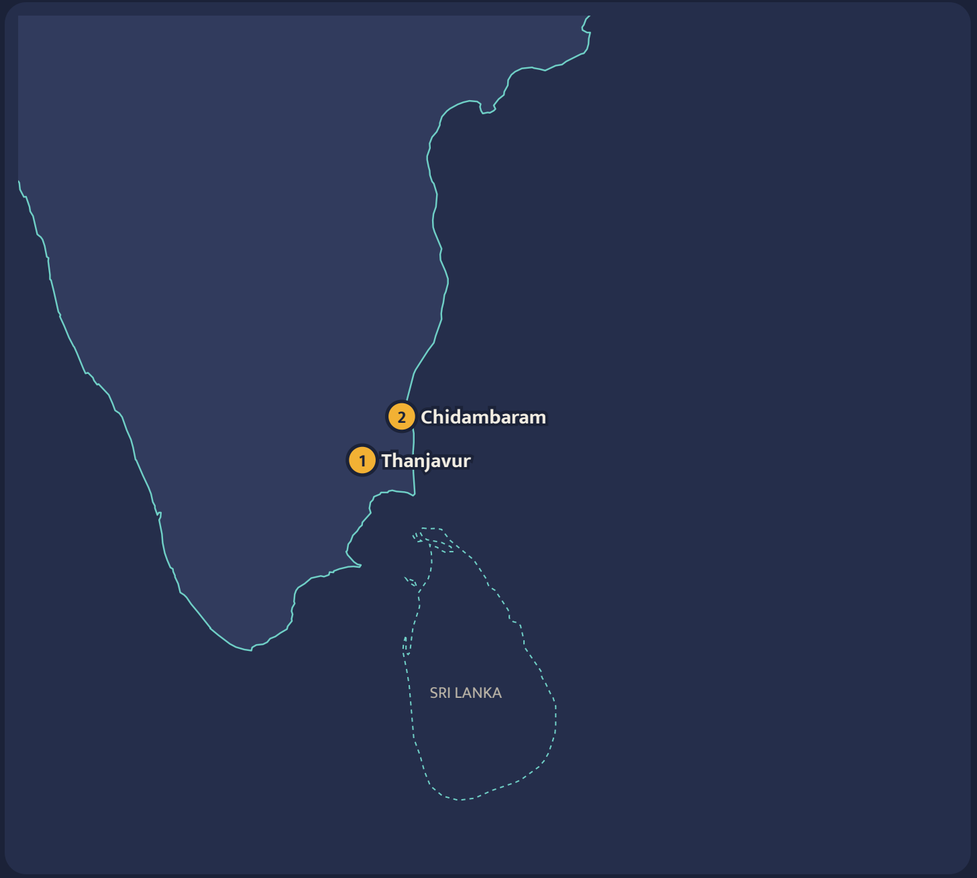
LEARN

Key terms

lost-wax casting	—	molding metal from a wax model
ananda tandava	AA-nun-da TAN-da-va	dance of bliss
repatriation	ree-pay-tree-AY-shun	returning objects to their place of origin

MAP

Where in the world?



1 **Thanjavur** Tamil Nadu

Brihadisvara temple, completed around 1010 CE by the Chola king Rajaraja I.

2 **Chidambaram** Tamil Nadu

Nataraja temple, honoring Shiva as the Lord of the Dance.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Thanjavur, Chidambaram and Temple Arts

WHOLE CLASS

Analyze a Nataraja image and a temple inscription.

YOUR TASK

Make a claim about how the Brihadisvara temple served Rajaraja's political power. Support it with two pieces of evidence (scale, inscriptions, location).

DISCUSS

Should sacred bronzes in foreign museums be returned to India's temples? Consider ownership, worship and preservation.

ACTIVITY

Read the Nataraja

Match each item on the left with one on the right.

1 Ring of fire	A Sound of creation
2 Damaru drum	B Release and grace
3 Abhaya hand (raised palm)	C Destruction and transformation
4 Fire in one hand	D Protection, “do not fear”
5 Foot on the dwarf Apasmara	E Overcoming ignorance
6 Raised foot	F The cosmos and its cycles

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Read the Nataraja

1 → F Ring of fire — The cosmos and its cycles

2 → A Damaru drum — Sound of creation

3 → D Abhaya hand (raised palm) — Protection, "do not fear"

4 → C Fire in one hand — Destruction and transformation

5 → E Foot on the dwarf Apasmara — Overcoming ignorance

6 → B Raised foot — Release and grace

QUIZ · QUESTION 1 OF 4

Who built Brihadisvara?

A Rajaraja Chola I

B Krishnadevaraya

C Ashoka

D Ahilyabai Holkar

Why are its inscriptions valuable to historians?

- **A** They record gifts, staff and pay
- **B** They are poems only
- **C** They predict the future
- **D** They list modern visitors

How were Chola bronzes made?

- **A** Printed
- **B** Carved from wood
- **C** Lost-wax casting
- **D** Woven

What does repatriation mean?

- **A** Returning objects to their place of origin
- **B** Rebuilding
- **C** Repainting
- **D** Renaming

QUIZ

Answers

1. **A. Rajaraja Chola I**

   Completed around 1010 CE.

2. **A. They record gifts, staff and pay**

   An archive in stone.

3. **C. Lost-wax casting**

   A wax model is replaced by metal.

4. **A. Returning objects to their place of origin**

   Several looted idols have been returned.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Make one claim about the Nataraja and support it with two visible details.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, APRIL 4, 2027

Class 18: Rameswaram and the Sea

Class 18

Rameswaram and the Sea

Sunday, April 4, 2027 · Unit 4: Southern and Western Temple Landscapes

PASSPORT SETU 2026-27

3 min Wonder | 7 min Learn | 3 min Map | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

How does one place hold an epic story, a geological feature and a modern political debate?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Rameswaram and the Sea

An island temple town

On Pamban Island in the Gulf of Mannar, linked to the mainland by road and rail bridges. A new vertical-lift rail bridge opened in 2025.

Ramanathaswamy

Famous for its long pillared corridors, often called the longest in India, and its 22 tirthams (wells) in which pilgrims bathe.

Ramayana links

In the Ramayana, Rama worships Shiva here. The chain of shoals toward Sri Lanka is called Rama Setu or Adam's Bridge.

Science and debate

Geologists study the shoals as natural formations. A proposed shipping canal (Sethusamudram project) through them met religious and environmental objections.

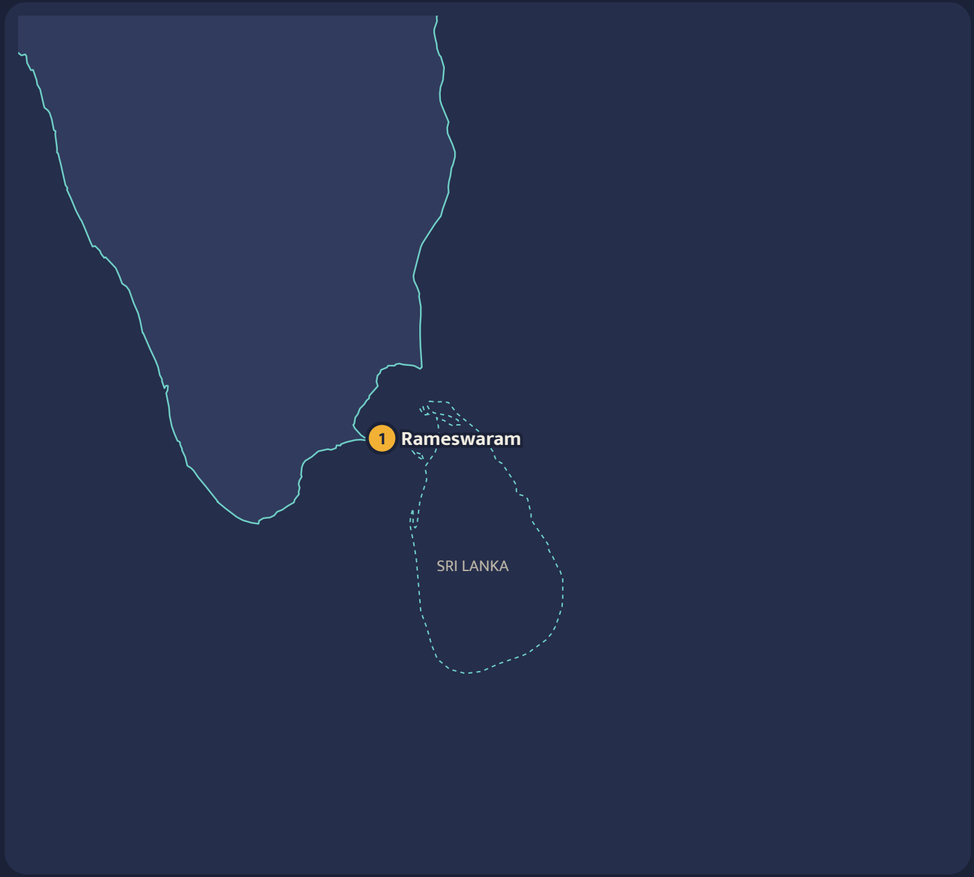
LEARN

Key terms

tirtham	TEER-tham	sacred water source
setu	SAY-too	bridge
shoal	SHOLE	shallow sandbank

MAP

Where in the world?



1 **Rameswaram** Tamil Nadu

Island temple town. Southern Char Dham with very long pillared corridors.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Rameswaram and the Sea

WHOLE CLASS

Compare a story map with a physical map of Rameswaram and the Palk Strait.

YOUR TASK

Evaluate the Sethusamudram debate: summarize the economic, environmental and religious positions, and explain which evidence each side relies on.

DISCUSS

Can scientific and sacred descriptions of the same place coexist? How?

ACTIVITY

Story map or physical map?

Place each card in a group.

- Bridge built by Hanuman’s army
- Coral reefs of the Gulf of Mannar
- Sandbanks across the Palk Strait
- Rama worships Shiva
- Pamban vertical-lift bridge
- Hanuman brings a linga from Kailash

NARRATIVE

PHYSICAL / SCIENTIFIC

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Story map or physical map?

NARRATIVE

- Rama worships Shiva
- Bridge built by Hanuman’s army
- Hanuman brings a linga from Kailash

PHYSICAL / SCIENTIFIC

- Sandbanks across the Palk Strait
- Pamban vertical-lift bridge
- Coral reefs of the Gulf of Mannar

QUIZ · QUESTION 1 OF 4

What is Adam's Bridge?

- **A** A chain of shoals between India and Sri Lanka
- **B** A temple gate
- **C** A steel bridge
- **D** A mountain pass

What was the Sethusamudram project?

- **A** A railway
- **B** A temple festival
- **C** A proposed shipping canal through the shoals
- **D** A dam

How many tirthams are inside Ramanathaswamy?

A 108

B 22

C 4

D 12

Rameswaram is located on...

A Pamban Island

B Andaman Islands

C Majuli

D Elephanta Island

QUIZ

Answers

1. **A. A chain of shoals between India and Sri Lanka**

   Also called Rama Setu.

2. **C. A proposed shipping canal through the shoals**

   It drew religious and environmental objections.

3. **B. 22**

   Pilgrims bathe in each.

4. **A. Pamban Island**

   In the Gulf of Mannar.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Answer: how can one place connect several stories and kinds of knowledge? Use Rameswaram as evidence.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, APRIL 11, 2027

Class 19: Hampi, Ellora, Khajuraho and Konark

Class 19

Hampi, Ellora, Khajuraho and Konark

PASSPORT CURATOR 2026–27

Sunday, April 11, 2027 · Unit 4: Southern and Western Temple Landscapes

3 min Wonder | **7** min Learn | **3** min Map | **9** min Explore | **5** min Quiz | **3** min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

When a temple is no longer used for worship, is it still sacred, or is it now a monument?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Hampi, Ellora, Khajuraho and Konark

Hampi

Capital of the Vijayanagara Empire (14th–16th c.), sacked after the Battle of Talikota in 1565. The Virupaksha temple has remained in worship.

Ellora

34 caves made by Hindu, Buddhist and Jain communities between about 600 and 1000 CE: a model of shared sacred space.

Khajuraho

Chandela temples built about 950–1050 CE; roughly 25 of an estimated 85 survive. Their sculpture spans gods, daily life and celestial figures.

Konark

13th-century Sun Temple by Narasimhadeva I, shaped as Surya's chariot with 24 wheels. The main tower has collapsed; worship there ended long ago.

LEARN

Key terms

living temple	—	still used for worship
monument	—	protected historic structure
ASI	—	Archaeological Survey of India

MAP

Where in the world?



1 **Hampi** Karnataka

Ruins of the Vijayanagara capital. The Virupaksha temple is still a place of worship.

2 **Ellora** Maharashtra

Hindu, Buddhist and Jain caves. The Kailasa temple was carved from one rock.

3 **Khajuraho** Madhya Pradesh

Chandela-era temples (about 950–1050 CE) with tall, curved Nagara towers.

4 **Konark** Odisha

13th-century Sun Temple shaped like the chariot of Surya, with 24 carved wheels.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Hampi, Ellora, Khajuraho and Konark

WHOLE CLASS

Become curators: choose four images for a mini-exhibit.

YOUR TASK

Organize the exhibit around one claim about art, power or landscape. Write a 50-word wall label for each image.

DISCUSS

Who should decide whether a protected monument can be used for worship again: archaeologists, devotees or the government?

ACTIVITY

Site and clue

Match each item on the left with one on the right.

1 Khajuraho	A Hindu, Buddhist and Jain caves together
2 Konark	B Chandela temples, about 25 survive
3 Hampi	C Sun temple shaped as a chariot
4 Ellora	D Empire capital sacked in 1565

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Site and clue

1 → B Khajuraho — Chandela temples, about 25 survive

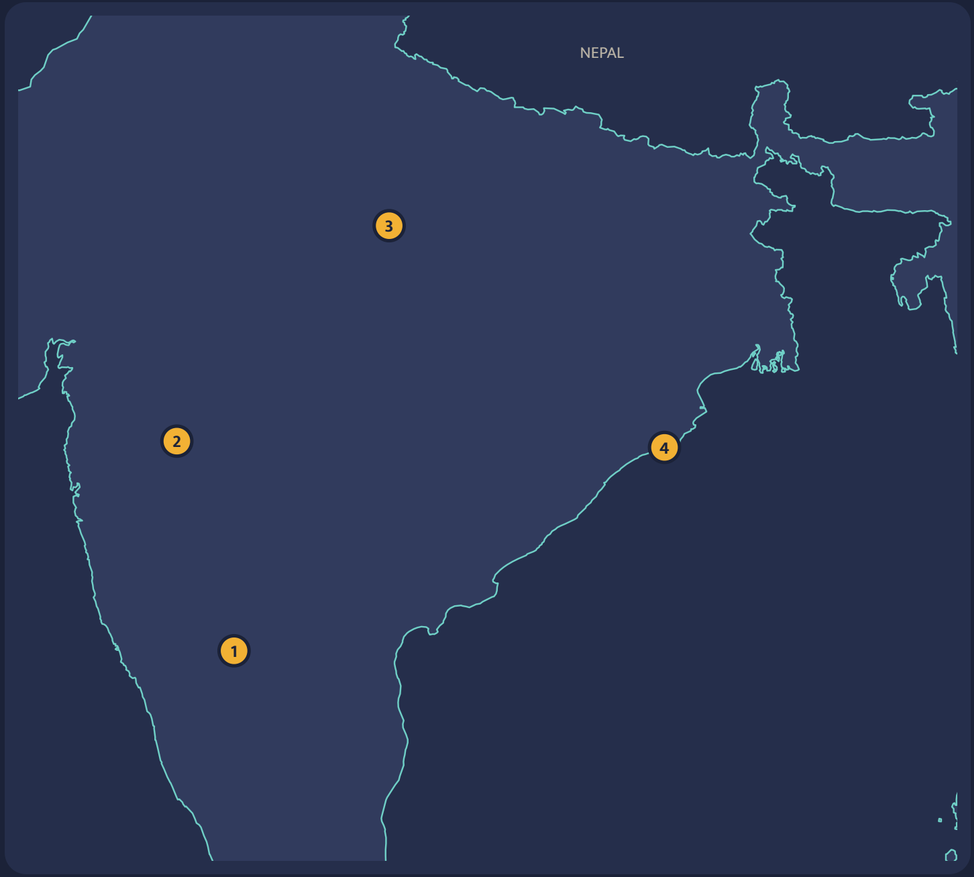
2 → C Konark — Sun temple shaped as a chariot

3 → D Hampi — Empire capital sacked in 1565

4 → A Ellora — Hindu, Buddhist and Jain caves together

ACTIVITY

Find the sites



Which number is each site?

Ellora → ___

Konark → ___

Hampi → ___

Khajuraho → ___

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Find the sites

1 Hampi

2 Ellora

3 Khajuraho

4 Konark

QUIZ · QUESTION 1 OF 4

Which battle led to Hampi's fall?

A Haldighati, 1576

B Talikota, 1565

C Plassey, 1757

D Panipat, 1526

Ellora is notable for…

A. Hindu, Buddhist and Jain caves side by side

B. Underwater shrines

C. Wooden temples

D. Only Jain caves

Which of these remains a living temple?

A All of them

B Virupaksha, Hampi

C Konark Sun Temple

D Ellora Cave 16

Who built the Konark Sun Temple?

A Narasimhadeva I

B Krishnadevaraya

C Ashoka

D Rajaraja I

QUIZ

Answers

1. **B. Talikota, 1565**

   The city was sacked afterward.

2. **A. Hindu, Buddhist and Jain caves side by side**

   Shared sacred space.

3. **B. Virupaksha, Hampi**

   Worship continues there.

4. **A. Narasimhadeva I**

   13th century, Eastern Ganga dynasty.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

State the one-sentence claim of your exhibit and defend your choice of images.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, APRIL 18, 2027

Class 20: Beyond India: Bali, Cambodia and the Global Hindu World

Class 20

Beyond India: Bali, Cambodia and the Global Hindu World

PASSPORT GLOBAL 2026-27

Sunday, April 18, 2027 · Unit 4: Southern and Western Temple Landscapes

3 min Wonder | 10 min Learn | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

When a tradition travels, what stays the same and what changes?

Think about your own family's traditions in the US.

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Beyond India: Bali, Cambodia and the Global Hindu World

Bali

Most Balinese practice Agama Hindu Dharma, blending Indic and local traditions. Pura Besakih, the “Mother Temple,” sits on Mount Agung; Tanah Lot stands on a sea rock.

Angkor Wat

Built in the early 12th century by Suryavarman II, dedicated to Vishnu. Its towers represent Mount Meru. It later became Buddhist and is on Cambodia’s flag.

How ideas traveled

Trade, courts, Brahmin advisers and Buddhist monks carried Sanskrit, epics and temple forms across Southeast Asia from the early first millennium CE.

The diaspora

Today Hindu temples stand from Trinidad to Toronto to Virginia, adapting architecture, languages and calendars to new homes.

LEARN

Key terms

Agama Hindu Dharma	—	Balinese Hinduism
Meru	MAY-roo	cosmic mountain
diaspora	dye-AS-po-ra	communities living away from an ancestral homeland

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Beyond India: Bali, Cambodia and the Global Hindu World

WHOLE CLASS

Photo detective stations: gates, towers, nature and offerings.

YOUR TASK

Write a comparison of Angkor Wat and a US diaspora temple: identify two continuities and two changes, and explain what caused the changes.

DISCUSS

Angkor Wat is now a Buddhist site and a national symbol. Who does a sacred place belong to when its religion changes?

ACTIVITY

Bali or Angkor Wat?

Place each card in a group.

- Mother Temple on a volcano
- Towers representing Mount Meru
- Daily canang sari offerings
- Appears on a national flag
- Built by Suryavarman II
- Temple on a sea rock

BALI

ANGKOR WAT

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Bali or Angkor Wat?

BALI

- Temple on a sea rock
- Daily canang sari offerings
- Mother Temple on a volcano

ANGKOR WAT

- Towers representing Mount Meru
- Built by Suryavarman II
- Appears on a national flag

Angkor Wat was first dedicated to...

A Brahma

B Shiva

C Vishnu

D Ganesha

QUIZ · QUESTION 2 OF 4

What is Agama Hindu Dharma?

A Balinese Hinduism

B An Indian temple

C A Cambodian dance

D A text

How did Indic religion reach Southeast Asia?

- **A** Trade, royal courts and religious specialists
- **B** Colonial missionaries
- **C** The internet
- **D** Military conquest by India

QUIZ · QUESTION 4 OF 4

Angkor Wat's towers symbolize...

A The Ganga

B A chariot

C A lotus pond only

D Mount Meru

QUIZ

Answers

1. **C. Vishnu**

   It later became Buddhist.

2. **A. Balinese Hinduism**

   It blends Indic and local practice.

3. **A. Trade, royal courts and religious specialists**

   Over many centuries.

4. **D. Mount Meru**

   The center of the cosmos.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Turn in Site Profile 2. Write one example of continuity and one of change in Hindu sacred spaces abroad.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, APRIL 25, 2027

Class 21: Temple Communities, Food and Service

Class 21

Temple Communities, Food and Service

PASSPORT SEVA 2026-27

Sunday, April 25, 2027 · Unit 5: Living Sacred Places: Community, Ethics, Stewardship

3 min Wonder | 10 min Learn | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

Who makes a temple work, and whose labor goes unnoticed?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Temple Communities, Food and Service

Many roles

Priests, cooks, musicians, artisans, cleaners, guides, vendors, administrators, volunteers and neighbors all sustain temples.

Seva

Selfless service is central in many Hindu communities. Diaspora temples in the US often depend almost entirely on volunteers.

Annadanam

Many temples serve free meals. Large ones, such as Tirumala, feed tens of thousands daily; shared meals can bring people of different backgrounds together.

Hereditary roles and change

Some temple roles have been hereditary. In recent decades, some states have trained and appointed priests from a wider range of backgrounds, sparking debate.

LEARN

Key terms

seva	SAY-vaa	selfless service
annadanam	un-na-DAA-nam	gift of food
archaka	AR-cha-ka	temple priest

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Temple Communities, Food and Service

WHOLE CLASS

Build a community web around a temple with role cards and yarn.

YOUR TASK

Interview plan: draft five respectful questions you could ask a local temple volunteer about how their temple runs. Then map the resources and challenges you expect.

DISCUSS

Should temple roles be open to anyone trained for them, or follow tradition? Present both perspectives fairly.

ACTIVITY

Roles and resources

Match each item on the left with one on the right.

1 Musician	A Time and skills
2 Flower vendor	B Garlands and supply chains
3 Archaka	C Budgets and records
4 Administrator	D Rituals, lamps and bells
5 Volunteer	E Large kitchens and ingredients
6 Cook	F Nadaswaram and drums

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Roles and resources

1 → F Musician — Nadaswaram and drums

2 → B Flower vendor — Garlands and supply chains

3 → D Archaka — Rituals, lamps and bells

4 → C Administrator — Budgets and records

5 → A Volunteer — Time and skills

6 → E Cook — Large kitchens and ingredients

QUIZ · QUESTION 1 OF 4

What does seva mean?

A. A tax

B. A ritual bath

C. Paid labor

D. Selfless service

What is annadanam?

A. A drum

B. A gate

C. A dance

D. Free shared meals

What do US diaspora temples often rely on?

- **A** Government funding
- **B** Hereditary kings
- **C** Tourism only
- **D** Volunteers

What debate surrounds some temple roles?

A. Whether they should be hereditary or open

B. None

C. Whether to use lamps

D. Whether to serve food

QUIZ

Answers

1. **D. Selfless service**

   Central to many temple communities.

2. **D. Free shared meals**

   The gift of food.

3. **D. Volunteers**

   Community members run classes, kitchens and festivals.

4. **A. Whether they should be hereditary or open**

   Tradition and equality are both at stake.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Explain why a sacred place needs many kinds of work, and name one form of labor people often overlook.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, MAY 2, 2027

Class 22–23: Etiquette, Heritage and Sustainable Pilgrimage

Class 22–23

Etiquette, Heritage and Sustainable Pilgrimage

PASSPORT CARE 2026–27

Sunday, May 2, 2027 · Unit 5: Living Sacred Places: Community, Ethics, Stewardship

3 min Wonder | **10** min Learn | **9** min Explore | **5** min Quiz | **3** min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

What does it mean to be a responsible visitor to someone else's sacred place?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Etiquette, Heritage and Sustainable Pilgrimage

Respectful visits

Common customs: remove shoes, dress modestly, follow photography rules, keep quiet in shrines, and ask before joining rituals. Rules vary; read signs and ask.

Who can enter

Entry rules differ: some temples restrict entry to Hindus or have historic gender restrictions, and court cases have challenged some of these. Accessibility for disabled visitors is improving unevenly.

Rivers and mountains

India’s Namami Gange program (launched 2014) targets Ganga pollution. Plastic bans and visitor caps have been tried at some sites.

Heritage management

The Archaeological Survey of India and UNESCO protect monuments, but living temples also need space for worship, festivals and change.

LEARN

Key terms

stewardship	STOO-erd-ship	responsible care
overtourism	—	more visitors than a place can bear
intangible heritage	—	living practices, not buildings

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Etiquette, Heritage and Sustainable Pilgrimage

WHOLE CLASS

Sort visitor choices, then run the heritage council: balance clean water, safe paths, local jobs, visitor numbers and conservation.

YOUR TASK

Write a one-page recommendation for one site addressing a sustainability problem. State the trade-off and who bears its costs.

DISCUSS

Can a site be both a protected monument and a living place of worship? What has to give?

ACTIVITY

Visitor choices

Place each card in a group.

- Follow signs on photography
- Photograph the inner shrine
- Remove shoes where asked
- Accept prasad with care
- Climb carvings for a selfie
- Join a ritual
- Touch the murti uninvited
- Leave plastic by the river

RESPECTFUL	ASK FIRST	NOT APPROPRIATE

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Visitor choices

RESPECTFUL

- Remove shoes where asked
- Follow signs on photography
- Accept prasad with care

ASK FIRST

- Photograph the inner shrine
- Join a ritual

NOT APPROPRIATE

- Climb carvings for a selfie
- Leave plastic by the river
- Touch the murti uninvited

QUIZ · QUESTION 1 OF 4

What is the best approach when rules are unclear?

- **A** Read signs and ask a volunteer
- **B** Do whatever you like
- **C** Copy tourists
- **D** Leave immediately

QUIZ · QUESTION 2 OF 4

When was Namami Gange launched?

A 2014

B 2024

C 1985

D 1947

QUIZ · QUESTION 3 OF 4

Which is intangible heritage?

- **A** Ellora caves
- **B** Hampi ruins
- **C** The Konark temple
- **D** The Kumbh Mela

A key tension in heritage management is…

- **A** Protecting monuments while allowing living worship
- **B** Selling tickets
- **C** Choosing paint colors
- **D** None

QUIZ

Answers

1. **A. Read signs and ask a volunteer**

   Customs vary widely.

2. **A. 2014**

   A national river clean-up program.

3. **D. The Kumbh Mela**

   A living practice.

4. **A. Protecting monuments while allowing living worship**

   Living temples change over time.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

State your recommendation in one sentence and name its main trade-off.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, MAY 9, 2027

Class 24: Capstone Workshop

Class 24

Capstone Workshop

Sunday, May 9, 2027 · Unit 5: Living Sacred Places: Community, Ethics, Stewardship

PASSPORT EXHIBIT 2026–27

3 min Wonder | 10 min Learn | 9 min Explore | 5 min Quiz | 3 min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

What is the single claim you want a visitor to leave your exhibit believing?

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Capstone Workshop

The task

Create a museum exhibit on one sacred place, one pilgrimage route or two connected sites.

Formats

Poster, model, audio tour, slideshow, map book or illustrated travel guide.

Requirements

Location map, timeline, architecture or landscape analysis, one present-day issue, a clear thesis and at least three credible, cited sources.

Language and evidence

Use emic and etic framing, avoid generalizing about all Hindus, and credit every image.

LEARN

Key terms

thesis	THEE-sis	main claim
citation	sigh-TAY-shun	source credit
peer review	—	feedback from classmates

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Capstone Workshop

WHOLE CLASS

Peer review in pairs: accuracy, respectful language, evidence and clarity.

YOUR TASK

Check off each requirement. Then exchange exhibits with a partner and give one strength, one question and one fix.

DISCUSS

What makes a source credible for this project? Compare a UNESCO page, a temple website and a travel blog.

ACTIVITY

Exhibit checklist

- ☐ Clear thesis
- ☐ Location map
- ☐ Timeline
- ☐ Architecture or landscape analysis
- ☐ One present-day issue
- ☐ Three credible sources, cited
- ☐ Credited images
- ☐ Respectful, accurate language

Which sentence best fits an exhibit label?

A “In this tradition, the river is honored as a goddess.”

B “Everyone believes this.”

C “Hindus always do this.”

D “All Hindus worship rivers.”

Which source is most credible for site history?

- **A** A rumor
- **B** A meme
- **C** An anonymous comment
- **D** UNESCO World Heritage Centre

How should a temple's own website be used?

- **A** As an emic source on beliefs and practices
- **B** As a weather source
- **C** As useless
- **D** As neutral history

A strong thesis is…

- **A** A list of facts
- **B** A title
- **C** A question only
- **D** A specific, arguable claim

QUIZ

Answers

1 **A. “In this tradition, the river is honored as a goddess.”**

Specific and accurate.

2 **D. UNESCO World Heritage Centre**

Use institutional and scholarly sources.

3 **A. As an emic source on beliefs and practices**

Know each source’s perspective.

4 **D. A specific, arguable claim**

Every element should support it.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Write your exhibit thesis and list your three sources.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

NEXT CLASS · SUNDAY, MAY 16, 2027

Class 25: Exhibition, Reflection and Synthesis

Class 25 · Annual Day

Exhibition, Reflection and Synthesis

PASSPORT SACRED 2026-27

Sunday, May 16, 2027 · Unit 5: Living Sacred Places: Community, Ethics, Stewardship

3 min Wonder | **7** min Learn | **3** min Map | **9** min Explore | **5** min Quiz | **3** min Reflect

WONDER · 3 MIN

What makes a place sacred? Compare your answer to the thesis you wrote in October.

Think · Pair · Share

LEARN

Exhibition, Reflection and Synthesis

Exhibition walk

Visit each exhibit at Annual Day and leave one compliment and one question.

Synthesis

Answer “What makes a place sacred?” with examples from at least three regions, one similarity and one difference.

Revisit your thesis

Compare your Class 1 thesis with your thinking now. What changed, and why?

Final reflection

Something I learned, something I still wonder, and one principle for studying religion respectfully.

LEARN

Key terms

tirtha	TEER-tha	sacred crossing
emic / etic	—	insider / outsider view
synthesis	SIN-the-sis	combining ideas into a whole

MAP

Where in the world?



1 **Varanasi (Kashi)** Uttar Pradesh

Ancient city on the Ganga with stone ghats and the Kashi Vishwanath temple of Shiva.

2 **Kedarnath** Uttarakhand

Shiva temple at about 3,580 m. One of the 12 Jyotirlingas.

3 **Dwarka** Gujarat

Western Char Dham. Dwarkadhish temple of Krishna beside the Arabian Sea.

4 **Puri** Odisha

Eastern Char Dham. Jagannath temple and the Rath Yatra chariot festival.

5 **Rameswaram** Tamil Nadu

Island temple town. Southern Char Dham with very long pillared corridors.

6 **Madurai** Tamil Nadu

Meenakshi Amman temple at the heart of a city on the Vaigai river.

7 **Kamakhya** Assam

Goddess temple on Nilachal Hill above the Brahmaputra, in Guwahati.

8 **Konark** Odisha

13th-century Sun Temple shaped like the chariot of Surya, with 24 carved wheels.

9 **Hampi** Karnataka

Ruins of the Vijayanagara capital. The Virupaksha temple is still a place of worship.

EXPLORE · 9 MIN

Exhibition, Reflection and Synthesis

WHOLE CLASS

Hold the exhibition walk at Annual Day. Families are welcome.

YOUR TASK

Write your synthesis paragraph using three regions, one similarity and one difference.

DISCUSS

Which site this year challenged your assumptions the most, and why?

ACTIVITY

Year in review map challenge



Which number is each site?

- Madurai → ___
- Konark → ___
- Hampi → ___
- Kamakhya → ___
- Puri → ___
- Dwarka → ___
- Varanasi (Kashi) → ___
- Rameswaram → ___
- Kedarnath → ___

ACTIVITY · ANSWERS

Year in review map challenge

1. Varanasi (Kashi)
2. Kedarnath
3. Dwarka
4. Puri
5. Rameswaram
6. Madurai
7. Kamakhya
8. Konark
9. Hampi

What did tirtha originally mean?

- **A** A ford or river crossing
- **B** A chariot
- **C** A drum
- **D** A tower

Emic describes…

- **A** The outsider’s analysis
- **B** The insider’s perspective
- **C** A river
- **D** A building style

Which site was carved from a single cliff?

A Konark

B Kedarnath

C Meenakshi

D Kailasa temple, Ellora

QUIZ · QUESTION 4 OF 5

Who built the Brihadisvara temple?

A Rajaraja Chola I

B Ahilyabai Holkar

C Suryavarman II

D Narasimhadeva I

Angkor Wat was first dedicated to...

A Buddha

B Shiva

C Vishnu

D Surya

QUIZ

Answers

1. **A. A ford or river crossing**

   Our first word of the year.

2. **B. The insider’s perspective**

   Etic is the outsider’s view.

3. **D. Kailasa temple, Ellora**

   Rock-cut architecture.

4. **A. Rajaraja Chola I**

   Around 1010 CE.

5. **C. Vishnu**

   It later became Buddhist.

REFLECT · 3 MIN

Passport time

Reflection

Final reflection: something I learned, something I still wonder, and one principle for studying religion respectfully.

EXIT TICKET

One word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

THANK YOU!

Congratulations on completing Sacred Geography.